Spread Love & Acceptance

FOR TWO OR MORE · SHORT VERSION

Spread Love & Acceptance

Understanding yourself and the people you share a life with

FOR TWO OR MORE · SHORT VERSION



by Christian

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

Spread Love & Acceptance: For two or more, the short version.
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This edition: October 2026. Made from the chapters at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, where they are kept up to date.

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Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

Research mentioned in the chapters is listed, with links, in the research notes at the back and at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)
Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868

Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Part Three, Chapter 12 (online) says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Chapter 16 (online) about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

How to use this book

This is a book about seeing what is really going on, in yourself and between people, without blaming anyone, and then changing one small thing. This copy holds 6 chapters in one part, in the short version. There is no wrong way in.

THE PARTS

> **Part Two: Between us.** One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.

TWO SIZES OF EVERY CHAPTER

Every chapter comes in a short version (about 10 to 15 minutes) and a full version with the research, more examples and more to try. This is the short version. The full version is free at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book.

READ IN ORDER, OR BY NEED

Read it front to back like any book, or start with the chapter that fits what is going on. Each chapter ends with *What to remember*, *This connects to* (the chapters that explain it or put it to use, with page numbers) and *Put it to use*, with codes you can scan for the matching tool.

IN EVERY CHAPTER

- A short scene: a made-up moment from everyday life.
- **Words you could use**: sentences to say out loud.
- **Try this**: one small thing to do this week.
- **Common mix-ups**: easy mistakes, and what is closer to true.

THE SITE, THE PROGRAM AND PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The book has a free website with the workpapers (pages you fill in) and tools (helpers you use) that the chapters mention; the next page explains both. Nothing you type there leaves your device, and there is no account. The **six-week program** (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01) puts Part Two to work a week at a time, and the **self path** does the same for Part One. **Professor Puddles**, the site's friendly guide, answers questions about the book's ideas.

GO GENTLY

Some chapters touch hard things: grief, shame, anger, worry, trauma. Skip anything that isn't right for today. Nothing here is a test, and nothing needs to be done all at once.

Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-03 **Workpapers: pages you fill in**

A workpaper is a page you fill in, on your own or together: a one-week log, a list of who owns which job, a short check. Each one has a number, like **WP-03**, and it is always called a workpaper, for example “Workpaper WP-03: One owner per job”. The blank workpapers are also at the back of this book, one page each, to copy.

TOOL **Tools: helpers you use on the site**

A tool is an interactive helper on the website: a quiz, a calm-down timer, a card maker, or the Chat analyzer that reads a message with you. You use it and it gives you something back. It is always called a tool, for example “Tool: Chat analyzer”.

The book keeps the two apart: a workpaper and a tool never share a list. Both are free, need no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Three friends who give hints



Professor Puddles, the site’s cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints: a thought to take with you, and the workpaper or tool that fits.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup with the big smile and the collar, bounds in now and then with a playful tip.



Sugarfoot, the steady, gentle pup with the long soft ears and the best hugs, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

Find it fast

Start with what is going on, not with chapter one. Each line points to the place in the book that helps most, and one tool to try. You can read that part on its own and stop.

SHARING THE LOAD

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
We keep arguing about chores.	Part Two · Chapter II · One owner per job	44	WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job
I do the remembering and planning, and nobody sees it (the mental load).	Preface to Part Two · The mental load	27	WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what
We each think we do more than our share.	Preface to Part Two · Why the other person doesn't see it	18	WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what
The same job keeps slipping, week after week.	Part Two · Chapter V · A repeat usually has no real owner	92	WORKPAPER WP-04 What keeps coming back?
Is the way we share things fair? Can it last?	Part Two · Chapter II · The setup score	44	TOOL Is the setup working for everyone?
We've just had a baby and we're both exhausted.	Part Two · Chapter II · Small children and a new baby	55	WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying?
We're about to move in together.	Part Two · Chapter V · Starting out: before you move in	103	TOOL The "Who does what?" page
Money between us feels unfair.	Part Two · Chapter IV · Money between you	89	TOOL Who does what? The Money tab
We co-parent across two homes.	Part Two · Chapter III · Two homes	73	WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job
We share a house with a housemate, or more than two of us share a home.	Part Two · Chapter IV · A couple and a housemate	89	TOOL The "Who does what?" page

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
I'm raising my grandchild (kinship care).	Part Two · Chapter V · Raising a grandchild	104	WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job
Faith matters to us, or family elders expect a say.	Part Two · Chapter I · Faith, culture and family voices	41	WORKPAPER WP-13 The 90-second daily check-in
I'm caring for a parent or partner, and it's wearing me down.	Part Two · Chapter III · When "full" has become normal	61	WORKPAPER WP-02 How much are you carrying?
I'm the only one who wants to try this.	Part Two · Chapter II · When only one of you is on board	58	WORKPAPER WP-01 Who did what (your side only)
Someone handed me this book, and I'm not sure why.	If someone handed you this book	11	WORKPAPER WP-03 One owner per job

TALKING IT THROUGH

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
Small things turn into big rows.	Part Two · Chapter I · How stress changes your frequency	31	WORKPAPER WP-11 The Calm-Down Kit
We move and talk at different speeds.	Part Two · Chapter I · What sets the frequency	31	WORKPAPER WP-12 Same moment, different speeds
A comment stings and I snap back.	Part Two · Chapter IV · Let a comment land before you react	83	WORKPAPER WP-09 Say it so it lands
Is it us, or is it everything else going on?	Part Two · Chapter III · Leftover stress	61	WORKPAPER WP-14 Is it us, or is it everything else?

HARD SEASONS

IF THIS IS GOING ON	READ	PAGE	TRY
I'm thinking about ending my life, or I'm worried someone is.	If you need help now	5	The page itself

This copy holds only part of the book, so this map lists the problems it covers. The whole book's map has 16 more, and every chapter is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book. Each thing to try is marked as a workpaper (a page you fill in) or a tool (a helper you use on the site). All are free on the website, with nothing to sign up for; each chapter's end has a code you can scan for them. Looking for a word rather than a problem? The index at the back lists the main ideas.

If someone handed you this book

Maybe it was left on your side of the bed with a page turned down. Maybe someone said, "Could you just read this bit?" Either way, you didn't choose it. Fair enough. Here is the short version, written for you.

This isn't a case against you

The book starts from something researchers have found again and again: when two people each estimate their share of the housework, the two answers usually add up to more than 100%. Nobody is lying. You see every minute of your own effort and only some of theirs, and so do they (Chapter II, page **44**). So the book never asks who the bad guy is. Its numbers score the setup, never a person.

What's in it for you

- Fewer repeat arguments about the same jobs.
- Jobs that are clearly yours, so nobody needs to remind you about them.
- Credit for what you already do. Your jobs go on the list too: the car, the bins, the late-night lifts, the things you fix.
- A say in what "fair" means in your house. It isn't always 50/50 (Chapter IV, page **76**).

It doesn't ask for therapy talk, and you never fill anything in about the other person. You can say no.

A first week: three small things

1. **Log your own week.** Rough minutes on "Who did what", including the thinking part: booking, remembering, planning. Ten minutes in all. Only yours, never theirs.
2. **Ask one question, and just listen.** "What's the one job you'd most like to stop thinking about?" Don't defend or count. Write the answer down.
3. **Take over that job, the whole of it,** including the noticing (below).

Words to open the talk

> "I read the bit you gave me. I don't agree with all of it, but I get the point about the stuff nobody sees."
> "I'd rather own a couple of things properly than 'help' with everything. Which one would you most like off your mind?"
> "Give me a week to see what I actually do. Then let's look together."

Best left out, for now: "Just tell me what to do" (it hands the thinking straight back), "You should have asked" and, in the first five minutes, "I do loads too." That may be true. Save it for when you both have your logs.

Taking over a whole job, noticing included

Every job has a part you can see (doing it) and parts you can't: noticing it needs doing, remembering, planning and checking it got done (the Preface, page **18**). Taking a job over means all of it.

1. **Pick one job that repeats:** the children's clothes and shoes, the bins, the car, school forms, the dentist.
2. **Get the handover once.** What it involves, when it's due, where things are, who to call. Ask your questions now, not every week.
3. **Move the remembering out of their head.** A phone reminder, the calendar, a list on the fridge: anywhere but the other person.
4. **Do it start to finish for a month** without being reminded. If you need reminding, fix your reminder, not the relationship.
5. **Do it your way.** If the result is fine, the method is yours. Their part is to let it be done differently.
6. **Ask for a backstop if you like:** someone who notices a slip and says so once, kindly. A backstop isn't a supervisor (Chapter II, page **44**).

A made-up example. Hester has always looked after the children's clothes: spotting toes at the end of shoes, school sizes, swimming kit, passing on what's outgrown. Wilf takes it over. Hester writes the handover note: sizes, the shop, which drawer holds the next size up. Wilf sets a reminder for the first Sunday of each month: "Shoes, uniform, kit." In week two he misses the PE kit for a school trip. Hester says once, "The trip kit is Thursday," and he adds "school letters" to his Sunday check. A month in, Hester says the biggest change is that she no longer thinks about shoes at eleven at night.

If you think it's already fair

Log your week anyway. If it comes out even, that is useful to know, and the book will say so: a fair score doesn't silence anyone, and a low one doesn't blame anyone. And if this book feels like the wrong place to start, Find it fast, page 9 lists other ways in.

The book in two pictures

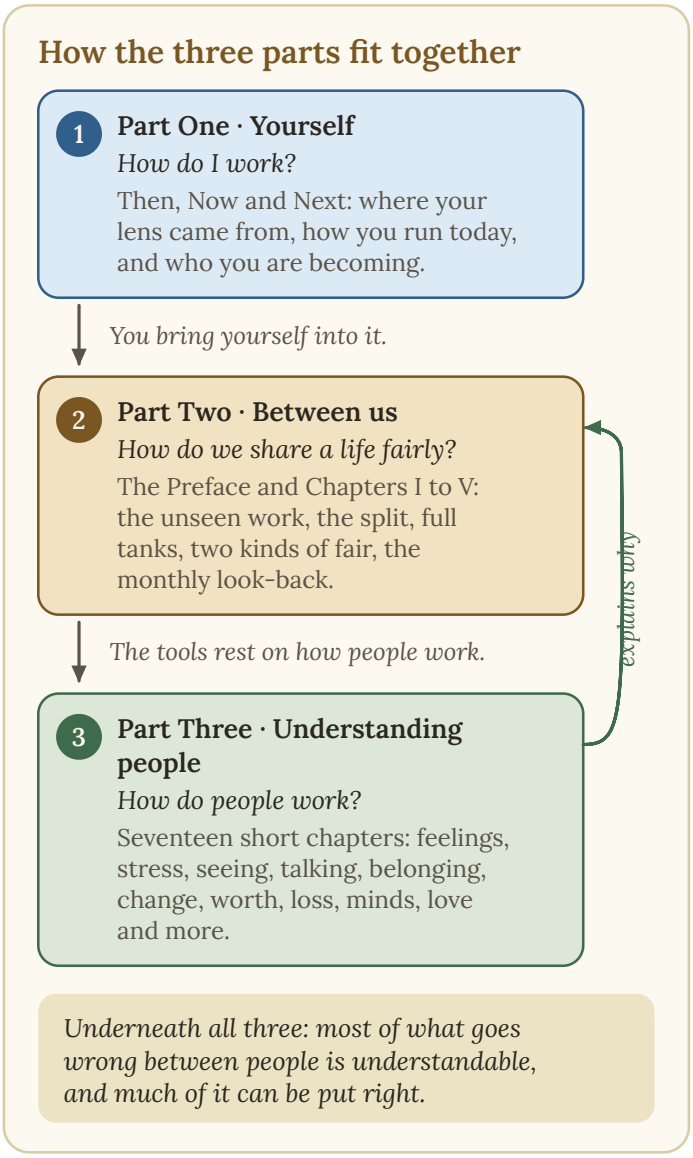


FIGURE 1 How the three parts fit together: you bring yourself into every shared life, and Part Three explains why the Part Two tools work.

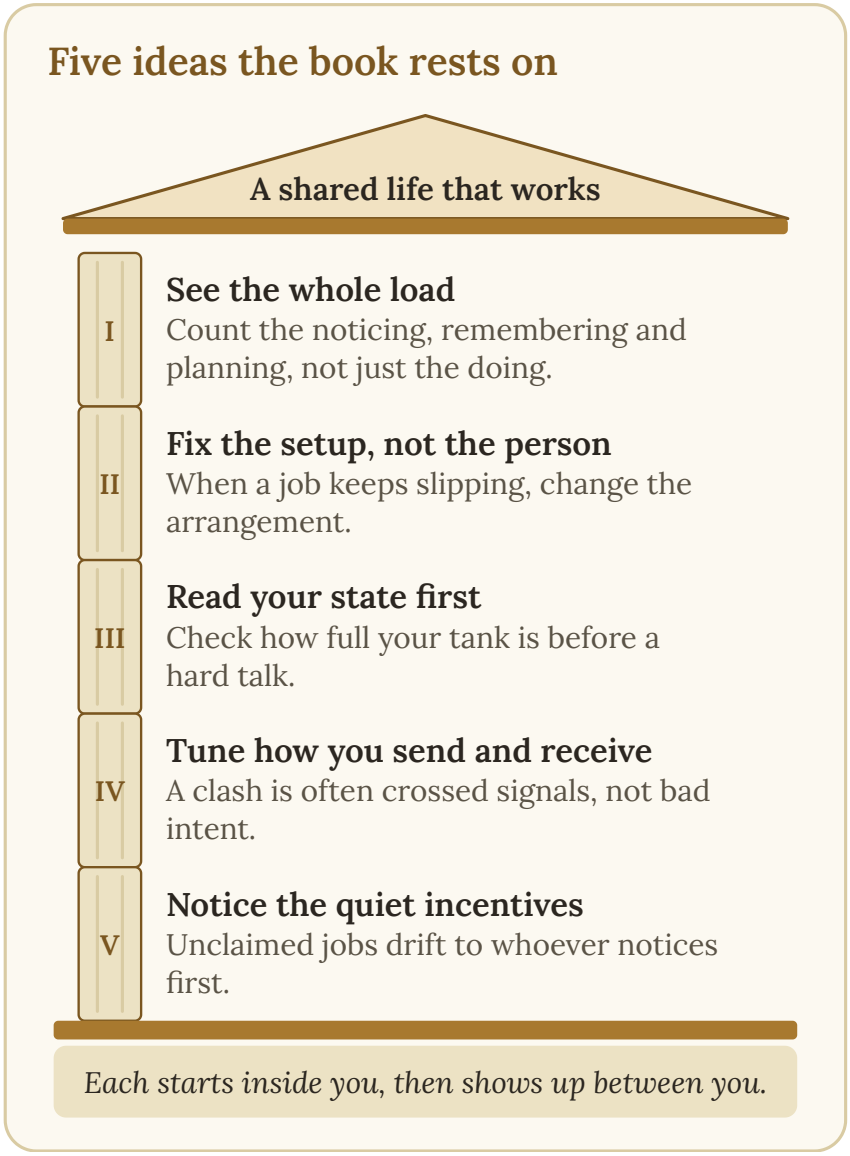


FIGURE 2 Five ideas the whole book rests on. Each one starts inside you, then shows up between you and the people you share a life with.

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PART TWO

Between us

One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.

IN THIS PART

Preface	The work nobody sees	18
Chapter I	Why we get out of tune	31
Chapter II	Is the split working?	44
Chapter III	Full tanks and different angles	61
Chapter IV	Two kinds of fair	76
Chapter V	The monthly look-back	92



TIDBIT

This part comes with workpapers to fill in, together or on your own. If you only try one, make it the one-week log.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01

Preface

PREFACE TO PART TWO

The work nobody sees: invisible labour at home

Part Two of the book is about the people you share a life or a home with, and it opens here. Running a life takes a lot of work that nobody sees. This preface helps you make that work visible, to yourself and to anyone you share it with, so you can talk about it fairly and kindly.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Unseen work quietly adds up
2. A lot of it is thinking, not doing
3. The other person usually just hasn't seen it
4. Writing it down isn't keeping score
5. Each of you writes only your own side
6. The borrowed words are there to take the blame away
7. One small step at a time
8. It can help in many kinds of shared life
9. The mental load: what the research says
10. On your own: your own unseen work
11. One household, followed for a month
12. Your situation, chapter by chapter
13. Common mix-ups
14. Limits and cautions

IN SHORT

- **Running a home takes unseen work**, the noticing, remembering and planning that many people call the mental load.
- **The other person usually just hasn't seen it.** This work hides by nature, and missing it says little about how much someone cares.
- **Each of you writes only your own side** of one ordinary week, and you read the two lists together.
- **The list is for seeing.** Thank each other for the past, and plan next week.

SUNDAY, 9PM

Someone notices that the laundry has been sitting in the washer since Saturday morning and will need doing again, that the school trip form is due on Tuesday, and that the birthday card for Auntie Jean is still in its cellophane on the hall table. They also notice that nobody else has noticed. From the hallway the house looks fine. That's exactly the trouble.

01

Unseen work quietly adds up.

Remembering appointments, noticing that the milk is low and calming a tense moment never show up on a calendar, so they rarely get a thank-you, and over months they pile up. This book calls the pile *unbilled debt*, because nobody ever sends a bill for it. (It's a ledger word, and I make no apology for it. I spent my career as a government auditor, and work that only got done because one person quietly kept catching it was a finding I saw again and again.) You can thank someone for what they carried before, and you leave the past unbilled. Marcus remembers every school form, dentist visit and bit of lunch money for their two children. His husband, Theo, sees two children who always seem to have what they need, PE kit included, and genuinely doesn't know how. He isn't careless. The work is out of his sight.

Tonight you could write down three things you did today that nobody saw, and leave the list alone for now. If you show it to someone later, something like "I'm not asking you to pay anything back. I just want you to see them" sets the right tone.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The easiest way to see unseen work is to write it down for one ordinary week. Each of you logs only your own jobs, and the thinking counts too.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01

02

A lot of it is thinking, not doing.

Before a job gets done, someone has to notice it, remember it, plan it and check that it happened. That thinking takes real time and energy even though nobody can see it. In a shared flat above a launderette, Yasmin

notices that the broadband deal ends in three weeks, compares six plans, picks one, sets it up and checks it went through. Paying took two minutes. The thinking took most of a Thursday evening, and nobody else in the flat knows it happened.

Pick one job at home and split it into its steps, noticing, planning, doing and checking, and then ask who usually does each step.

The work nobody sees

Most of a job happens before and after the doing.

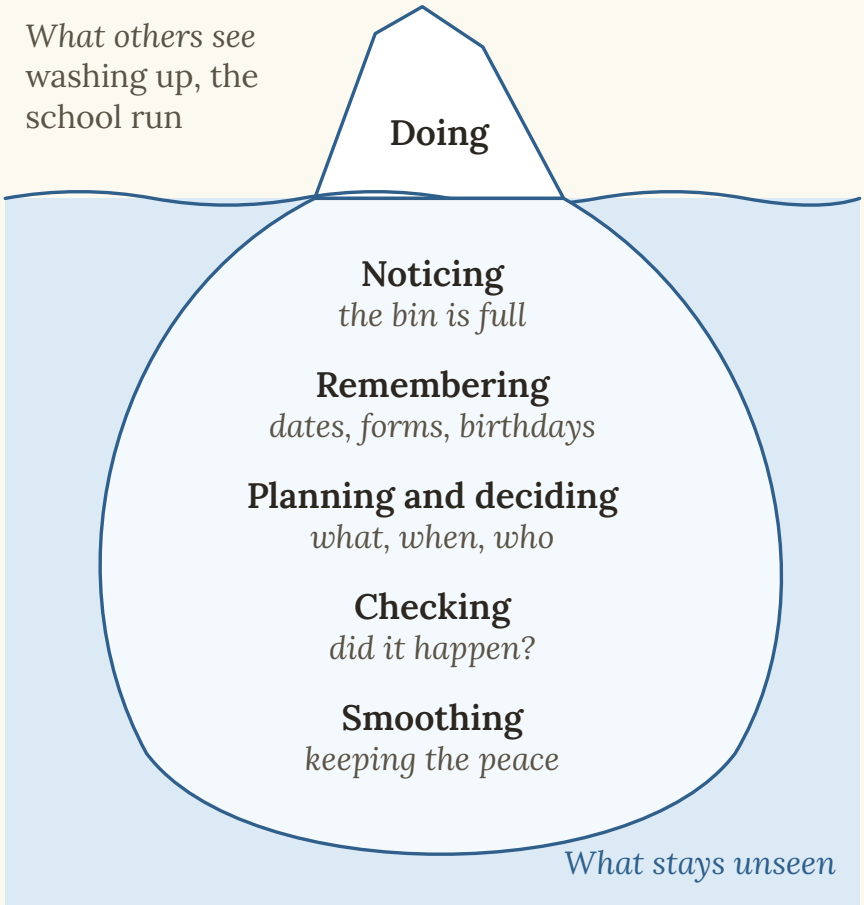


Illustration. The five kinds are this book's plain words; researchers call the thinking part "cognitive labour" (Daminger, 2019).

FIGURE 3 The work nobody sees. Most of a job happens before and after the doing, and whoever holds that part can never fully switch off.

03

The other person usually just hasn't seen it.

When this work is done well, nothing seems to happen, so the other person is rarely ignoring it. From where they stand, things appear to take care of themselves. Edna minds her grandchildren three afternoons a week and quietly moves her own doctor's appointments to fit, while her daughter believes it all slots in easily. A gentle question often opens it up ("What's something you do that you think I don't see?"), followed by listening without explaining.

Sometimes it only becomes visible when the person who carried it has gone. A widower finds out, slowly, over his first winter alone, how many jobs his wife quietly held: the birthday cards, the boiler service, knowing who to ring when someone was ill. He never saw them until they stopped getting done. If that's where you are, the section for people on their own, further on in this chapter, was written with you in mind.

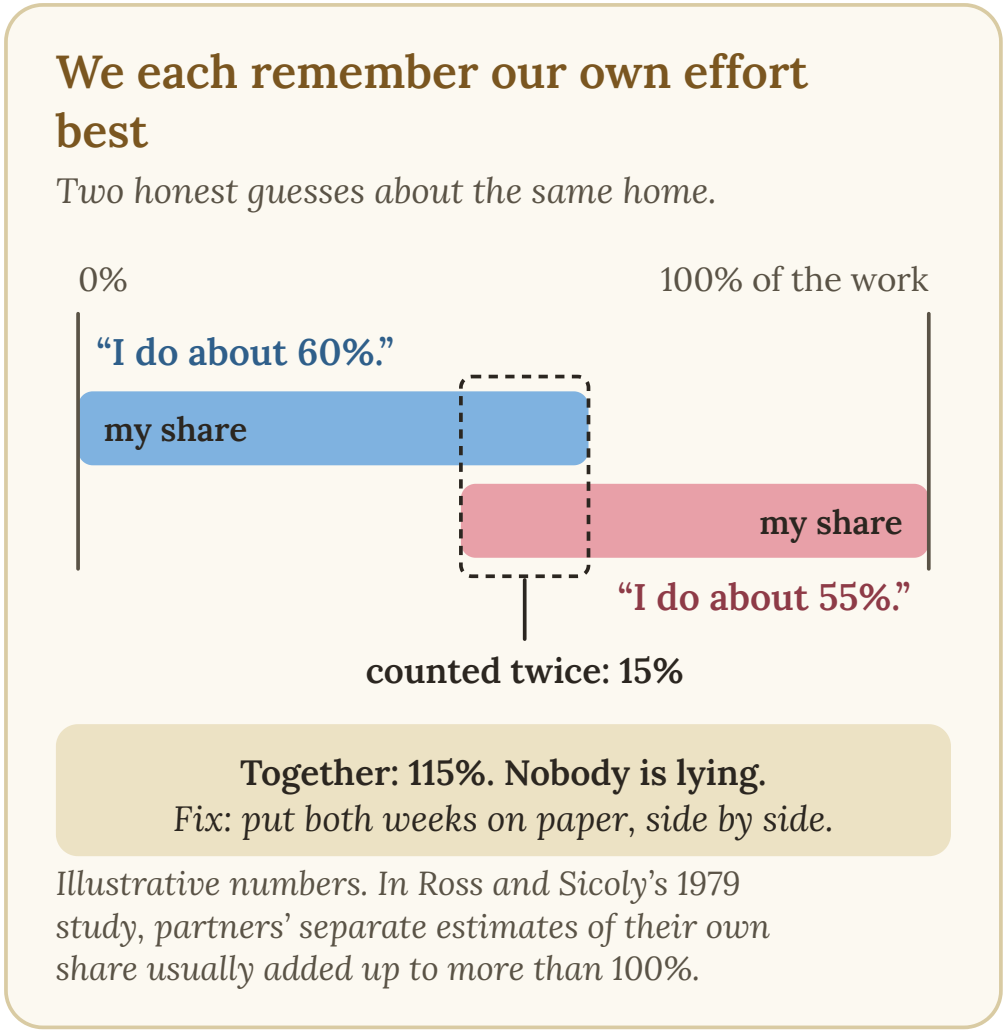


FIGURE 4 We each remember our own effort best. Illustrative numbers; in Ross and Sicoly's 1979 study, partners' estimates of their own share usually added up to more than 100 percent.

04

Writing it down isn't keeping score.

The point is for both of you to see the same picture, in the same words, at the same time, so that the talk starts from facts you share. This book calls that shared record a *ledger*, a plain list of who did what, kept for seeing. Two colleagues who job-share each list a week of tasks and find that every difficult client call has landed on the same one of them. They leave last year alone and agree to take turns with the Friday calls. Before you show anyone a

list, ask yourself honestly whether it's to plan next week or to prove a point. If it's the second, keep it in the drawer for now.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

Who did what

Marcus and Theo, a couple

Who did what

Person A
Marcus

Person B
Theo

Week beginning
5 October 2026

Part A: Who did what, this week

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Mon	*Plan the week's meals*	*Theo*	20	*Thinking and planning*
Mon	*Cook dinner*	*Marcus*	45	*Asked for*
Tue	*Book the boiler service*	*Theo*	15	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Dishes*	*Marcus*	20	*Asked for*
Wed	*Laundry, wash to put away*	*Theo*	60	*Noticed and handled*
Thu	*Remember Marcus's mum's birthday card*	*Theo*	10	*Thinking and planning*
Fri	*Bins and recycling out*	*Marcus*	10	*Noticed and handled*
Sat	*Big food shop*	*Both*	70	*Asked for*

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

Marcus
110 minutes (44%), of which 10 noticed and handled without being asked

Theo
140 minutes (56%), of which 105 noticed and handled without being asked (30 of them thinking and planning)

Workload balance score
0.88. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

Unasked-for work
Theo did 91% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no

Left blank this week.

Made-up example.

Fill in your own: Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01)

05

Each of you writes only your own side.

Nobody fills in anything for the other person. You each note what you did and then read the two lists together, which keeps it fair and keeps it kind. Each of you also adds the context only you have, such as a long week at work or children off school with colds, so that you both understand what you read. Arran, Dani and Sol are three partners sharing a rented house, and each writes only their own list. Reading them together at the kitchen table, Sol learns for the first time that Arran has been ringing the landlord about the damp every single month since February.

06

The borrowed words are there to take the blame away.

The book uses a few terms from accounting and science because they describe what is happening without saying whose fault it is. Each one is explained in plain words, and you never need them to use anything here. Two brothers share their mum's care, and one of them swaps "You never help" for "There's some unseen work here we haven't looked at." His brother finds it much easier to hear. If words like "ledger" or "debt" feel heavy, use your own. "Our list" and "the stuff nobody sees" do the same job.

07

One small step at a time.

Each chapter adds one idea and one tool, and one week of notes is enough to start. Later come a 90-second daily check-in about how much you were carrying that day, and a monthly look-back that needs only a few lines a week. A nurse on nights and a partner on days hardly see each other awake, so they start with one week of notes stuck to the fridge with a magnet from Whitby, and change nothing yet. Your first step can be as small as picking a start day and setting one reminder.



TIDBIT

Counting jobs isn't keeping score. It's looking for the work nobody noticed, and the quick split check is a good place to start.

TOOL **Who does what? Quick look** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand

08

It can help in many kinds of shared life.

Partners, families, housemates, co-parents and coworkers all share unseen work. The examples often use a couple at home, and the ideas fit anyone who shares a load. In a foster home, the carer keeps track of family visits and social worker calls, while a teenager in the home quietly cooks for the younger ones twice a week, and both kinds of work deserve to be counted.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't make anyone see the unseen work, and you can't write their side of the ledger. You can write your own side honestly, say it once, kindly, and then match what you take on to what comes back. If you keep carrying more than your share with nothing in return, stepping back towards your share isn't a punishment. It protects the energy you need to stay kind. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

FRIDAY, AFTER WORK

"You didn't have to do all that," they say, and they mean it kindly. You think: someone did have to. The list only ever lived in your head, so to them it looked as if it took care of itself, the way a house seems to clean itself if you're never in it on a Saturday morning.

The mental load: what the research says

Many people call the thinking side of home life the **mental load**, meaning the noticing and planning that come before a job gets done and the checking after. It includes knowing the baby needs the next size of clothes, and remembering the form and the party present. It is real work, even when it doesn't look like any.

Studies of couples find some patterns, *on average*. In couples of a man and a woman, women tend to do more of the noticing and checking (Allison Daminger, 2019). After a first baby a gap often opens, and in one study of working couples, mothers took on most of the new childcare while keeping their paid hours (Jill Yavorsky and colleagues, 2015). Arlie Hochschild called the home work that starts after paid work ends "the second shift."

There is a fair point on the other side too. Sometimes the parent who knows how things are done holds on to that, without meaning to, which researchers call *gatekeeping*. When a parent openly invites the other in and lets them do it their own way, the other parent tends to do more of the care (Sarah Allen and Alan Hawkins, 1999; Sarah Schoppe-Sullivan and colleagues, 2008).

These are averages across many homes, and they say nothing certain about yours. In your home it may be the other way round, or already even, or shared between two men or two women, which is why the book asks you to look at your own week on paper instead of guessing.

Hollie and Gareth have a toddler and a baby, and Gareth works shifts. Their week's minutes come out nearly even, yet Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked anyone to do. Their week is in Chapter II (page 55).

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "You do lots of the doing. It's the remembering I'd love you to take some of, whole jobs, start to finish." Or the other way round, "Show me once how you like it done, then let me do it my way."

On your own: your own unseen work

You don't need anyone else to start seeing the unseen. For one week, notice the jobs only you remember (the appointments, the smoothing-over) and write them down for yourself. Count it without charging for it, since the point is to see your real load so that you can plan your energy. Notice which jobs are yours by choice and which simply landed on you, and pick one you could hand back or do less often. Nicola, divorced, has the children every other week, and on paper she sees that she is still buying the birthday presents for both sides of the family, four years after the divorce. She hands his side back in one friendly message, and he replies with a thumbs-up and, to her surprise, "fair enough". More for people living alone or after a breakup is on On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

One household, followed for a month

Three adult siblings share the care of their father, who lives alone in the house they grew up in. On paper the visits are split evenly, two days each. When each of them writes a week of their own side, the picture changes. The eldest, Ffion, also holds the prescriptions, the hospital letters and the calls to the GP, none of which counts as a visit. Their brother is surprised and a little defensive, and the first conversation ends early. A month later they try again,

and he takes over the prescriptions completely, with the reminders on his own phone. Their sister still finds the hospital letters too much to face, so Ffion keeps them for now, and they agree to look again in the spring. The ideas in this chapter fit friendships, teams and shared houses in the same way, and Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) has a page for many kinds of shared life.

Your situation, chapter by chapter

Some situations get their own section:

- **Faith, culture, elders and in-laws.** Chapter I (page 41)
- **Small children or a new baby.** Chapter II (page 55)
- **Two homes after a split, and step-parents.** Chapter III (page 73)
- **Money between you, and a couple with a housemate.** Chapter IV (page 89)
- **New together, or grandparents raising a grandchild.** Chapter V (page 103)

Common mix-ups

"If it mattered, they'd have asked for help" misses how hidden this work is, often from the person doing it, until it's written down. Nobody needs exactly 50/50 either; what you're after is a split you can both see and both agree to. Please don't start by going over the last ten years. Start with one ordinary week, and thank each other for the past without trying to settle it. And the one doing less usually isn't the one who cares less. Usually they just can't see it yet, and once you've both seen it, what happens next is a choice you make together.

To start, each of you can list the things you did this week that nobody saw, then swap lists, read the other one slowly and say one thing on it you hadn't noticed before. Pick one item from their list and say thank you for it in a specific way. If writing things down isn't your style, a ten-minute talk over a cup of coffee with the same questions works too. Fixing comes later, once you have both seen the same picture. Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01) turns this into a gentle week-long log, and How to say

a specific thank-you (spreadloveandacceptance.com/turning-toward) has more ideas.

Limits and cautions

These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A list should never be demanded, checked over your shoulder, or used to keep track of where you go or what you spend. If that is happening, it isn't a ledger. It's control, and it's not your fault. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs). If you are a counsellor or group leader using this book with others, see For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors).

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working? page 44
Putting the unseen work into numbers you both trust

Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other read online
Why each person sees their own work first

Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well read online
Care work and how not to burn out

Part Two · Chapter IV · Two kinds of fair page 76
What fair means to each of you, before you talk

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 1: see the work that's already happening
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01

I

PART TWO · CHAPTER I

Why we get out of tune: communication at home

Why two kind, reasonable people can end up in a tangle neither of them started, and how to get back in step.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. The tangle often isn't about the words
2. Nearly in step is the noisy part
3. Three things knock you out of tune
4. Stress changes your station
5. Nobody has to be wrong
6. Get back in tune before you carry on
7. Go back in with a clear sentence
8. Small daily check-ins keep you in tune
9. Faith, culture and family voices
10. On your own: your side of the tuning
11. One example, followed through
12. Common mix-ups

IN SHORT

- **A clash is often about how things were said.** Pace, tone and urgency can be out of step even when both of you mean well.
- **Nobody has to be wrong.** Say that you are out of tune, pause with a time to come back, and slow down.
- **Go back in with one clear sentence** that says what happened, how you feel and what you would like.
- **A 90-second daily check-in** keeps small drifts small.

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

"I said I'd do it."

"I know, I'm just asking when."

Four sentences later nobody is talking about the bins any more. Somebody has mentioned last Christmas. Neither of you could point to the moment it turned.

The radio picture in this chapter is my own. The About page on the website describes how, for years, my closest relationships "filled up with static", with the same misunderstanding arriving again and again, and how what was missing was never care, on either side. It was timing, and a shared way of putting things. This chapter is the shared way.

01

The tangle often isn't about the words.

Two people can each say something perfectly reasonable and still clash, because the tone underneath doesn't match. Think of two radios slightly out of tune with each other. Together they make a crackle that neither of them was making alone.

One housemate asks, "Is anyone using the oven tonight?" The other says, "Why, did I leave a mess?" A plain question about a lasagne has been heard as a complaint about a baking tray. After your next small clash, ask yourself whether it was the words or the way they came out. It's usually the way.

YOU COULD SAY

"I think the words were fine. Something in how we said them got crossed."

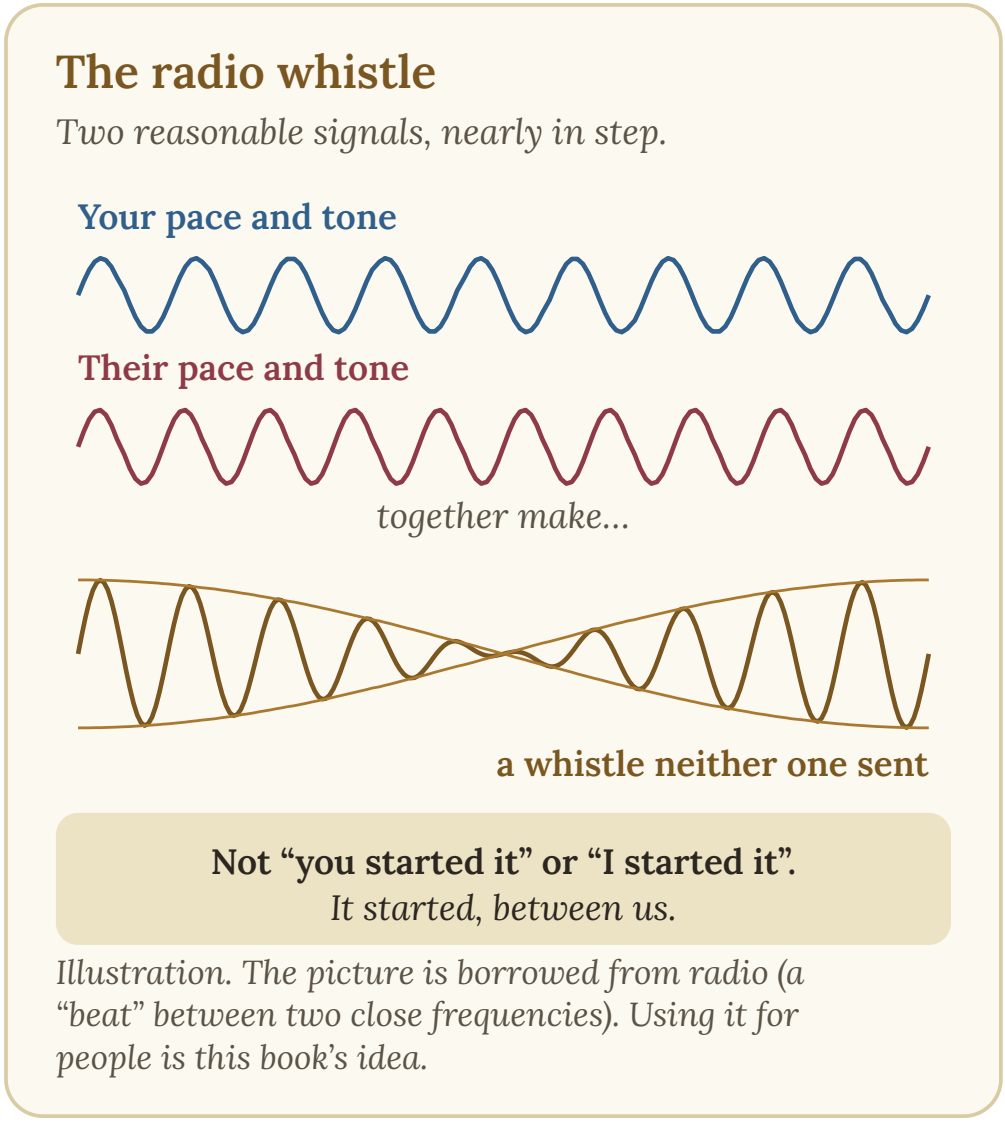


FIGURE 5 The radio whistle. Two reasonable signals, nearly in step, can make a clash that neither person started: it started between you.

02

Nearly in step is the noisy part.

Radios on very different stations don’t whistle at each other. The whistle comes when they are close but not quite matched, which is why people who know each other well can still clash. Research suggests we check our

meaning less with people we're close to, because we assume they already understand us.

Two sisters who talk on the phone every day argue about holiday plans far more often than either of them does with the cousins they see once a year at a christening or a funeral. The cousins get spelled out; the sisters get shorthand. With someone close to you, check one meaning today: "Just so I've got it right, you mean…?"

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I think I assumed you knew what I meant. Let me say it more clearly."



TIDBIT

Compare your daily rhythms: whose engine runs fast in the morning, and whose at night? Different speeds aren't wrong, they're just different.

TOOL **Rhythms side by side** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration`

03

Three things knock you out of tune.

How fast you're talking is one. Tone is another, as when a simple update is heard as a complaint. The third is how urgent something feels, since "when you get a chance" can mean tonight to one person and some time next week to another. Texts lose most of their tone, which makes urgency especially easy to misread.

One of two business partners texts "Need to talk" between meetings. The other reads it as a crisis and lies awake until two in the morning running through every possible disaster, including the bank. It turns out to be about the printer. Add a time to your next request, so "at some point" becomes "by Friday", and an update can say it's an update.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"By when would be good?" "Is this an update, or a worry?"

04

Stress changes your station.

When you are tense, you may talk faster and be more likely to hear a pause as a snub. When you are tired and flat, your replies get slower and shorter. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks), a thirty-second self-check, gives you a best guess at which state you are in.

A dad gets home from a night shift at the depot and answers his teenage son in single words. “Fine.” “Yep.” “Later.” His son decides he doesn’t care. He’s simply running on empty, and he’d tell you so if he had the words left.

> WORDS TO TRY
> “I’m running low right now, and it isn’t about you. Can we talk after I’ve slept?”

05

Nobody has to be wrong.

Two radios that both work perfectly will still crackle if they are slightly off, and arguing about whose fault the static is won’t clear it. Retuning will, which just means getting back in step.

A grandmother tells her grown-up son, at the door, that he looks tired. She means it as care. He hears “you’re not coping”. Both of them are right about what they meant and what they heard, which is exactly why arguing about it goes nowhere. In your next clash, try “we” instead of “you”: “We got crossed there.”

> YOU COULD SAY
> “I don’t think either of us meant it that way. Can we try that again?”

06

Get back in tune before you carry on.

Say out loud that you think you’re out of sync, and check how tense you feel. Either of you can call a pause, and whoever pauses names a time to come back. Slow down, take shorter turns, and only then go back to the actual topic.

Two roommates in halls agree on a pause word on a calm Sunday, and they pick “static” because it makes them laugh. Three weeks later, in the middle of a row about someone’s music at one in the morning, one of them says it. They stop. They come back at nine the next evening, as agreed, and sort it out in ten minutes. Agree a pause word with someone today, while you’re both calm.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> “I need ten minutes. I’ll come back at half past.”

Retuning, step by step

Before you carry on with a talk that has started to whistle.

1. **Name the mismatch, without blame**
   "I think we're on different wavelengths."
2. **Check your own state**
   Revved up or running on empty? Pause, and name a time to come back.
3. **Slow the pace on purpose**
   Shorter turns, more pauses, a lower voice.
4. **Then go back to the topic**
   It still matters. Now you can both hear it.

This book's four steps. Anyone can call a pause, and nobody should be blocked from leaving the room.

FIGURE 6 Retuning, step by step, before you carry on with a talk that has started to whistle.

07

Go back in with a clear sentence.

When you return to the topic, say what happened, how you feel and what you'd like, in that order and in one go. "The bins go out early on Wednesday morning. I get anxious when they're late. Could you put them out tonight?" Or, from one co-parent to another: "The swim kit wasn't in the bag and I felt stressed at drop-off. Could you pack it on Sunday nights?" It's worth writing one of these about something small before you need it, so the shape is in your hand when you do.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When you go back in, one clear sentence beats a speech. This workpaper helps you shape it before you say it.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

08

Small daily check-ins keep you in tune.

A short chat each day, like the 90-second daily check-in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in), makes tiny corrections before small things drift into a big argument. Habit research suggests small routines at a regular time are easier to keep than big ones done rarely. The quiet, easy stretches are the ones that drift most, so keep it going even when nothing seems wrong (see Complacency, spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency).

A long-distance couple, one in Leeds and one in Toronto, send each other one 90-second voice note every morning. On the weeks they forget, they notice the difference by Thursday, usually as a slightly odd phone call about nothing much.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
>
> "Today I was carrying quite a lot. One thing I liked today was…"

Pick a time and a cue (straight after dinner works for a lot of people) and try it for three days.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

The 90-second daily check-in

Priya and Dev, a couple on different shifts

The 90-second daily check-in

Person A
Priya

Person B
Dev

Week beginning
5 October 2026

Each day

Day	Person	Stress tank	One thing I appreciated today	One small thing that didn't feel great	One thing that would help tomorrow
Mon	*Priya*	*High*	*You left soup in the fridge before my night shift*	*Woke up to the washing still in the machine*	*A text when you're leaving work*
Mon	*Dev*	*Medium*	*Your note on the kettle*		*Bins out before I go at six*
Tue	*Priya*	*High*	*You kept the house quiet till noon*		*Ten minutes together at the shift change*
Tue	*Dev*	*Light*	*You booked the car in*	*Missed you at dinner again*	
Wed	*Priya*	*Medium*	*Breakfast together at 8*		*Early night*
Wed	*Dev*	*Medium*	*You remembered my mum's call*		

STRESS TANK THIS WEEK

Priya
2 high, 1 medium, 0 light

Dev
0 high, 2 medium, 1 light

The weekly catch-up

Sore spot that keeps coming up	Times this week	Move to
Washing left in the machine	2	*One owner per job*
Missing each other at dinner	2	*Keep watching*

Made-up example. One sentence each, then just listen: no debating, no solving.

Fill in your own: The 90-second daily check-in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control what you send, whether you check how it landed, and whether you step out to retune. You don't control how it's heard or how fast the other person settles. Matching energy here means matching care and effort, never volume: if someone gets louder, you don't have to follow. Stay at your level, and give the conversation the energy it gives back. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

SATURDAY, 10AM

One of you says the spare room needs clearing out at some point. She meant this month, and he heard today and has already cancelled his plans in his head. By lunchtime you are both upset about a room nobody has touched, and when you stop to ask what "at some point" meant, you find you are still not sure you agree.

Faith, culture and family voices

For many couples, faith is where they turn first, and a shared faith can be one of the strongest tools for staying in tune. Praying together, or a quiet moment after worship, can serve as a daily check-in. Some couples each pray on their own before they come back to a hard talk, with the pause still ending at a named time. A pastor, imam, rabbi, priest or trusted elder can be a good first person to talk to, and many can suggest a trained counsellor who shares your faith.

Emeka and Ngozi, married for twenty-six years, do their monthly look-back on a Sunday after church, over lunch. When a talk gets heated, either of them can say, "Let's pray on it and come back at eight," and they do.

Culture shapes how you talk too. In many families, respect for elders decides who can speak plainly to whom, and one habit helps a great deal, which is that each of you speaks to your own parents and relatives once you have agreed the message together.

> WORDS TO TRY
>
> "Can we pray about this and talk again tonight?" "Mum, we love you, and we've thought about it carefully. This year we'll visit in August instead of at Easter."

From two faiths or cultures? See Two faiths or cultures, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths).

On your own: your side of the tuning

Getting out of tune takes two, but retuning can start with one. You can learn your own pace and your own sense of urgency, so you notice when you are the one running fast or slow. Learn your early signs of drifting. A clipped reply is a common one, and so is a sudden need to win. Learn how you take words in best and say it once, as in "I hear things better in writing." When you drift, step out, settle and come back, which you can do without anyone's permission. Hamid lives alone and has noticed that his texts to friends come

out short when he is tired, so now he waits until morning to answer anything that matters (more in On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

One example, followed through

Cerys, Marisol and Dougie share a house and a car, and two of them talk fast while the third, Dougie, talks slowly. At house meetings Dougie kept getting talked over, and for a while the other two read his silence as agreement. It came out in March, when he said he had never actually agreed to the new car rota. They tried a simple change, a round in which each person speaks once before anyone answers. It felt stilted at first, and Cerys kept wanting to jump in. By the third meeting Dougie was saying more, and the rota he suggested is the one they now use. They still have the occasional evening when the meeting turns into two fast talkers and one quiet one, and someone usually says "round" to reset it. Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) has pages for many other kinds of shared life.

Common mix-ups

Retuning isn't giving in. You still come back to the topic, at a time when you can hear each other. Being out of sync doesn't mean one of you is wrong, either; two fair points in two different tones will still clash. And a pause never means the topic is dropped. A pause always comes with a time to come back, or it isn't a pause.

To try it, agree on a shared phrase while things are calm, such as "I think we're out of tune", so that it works as a signal when you need it. For one week, each of you can note one moment you felt out of step, and at the end you can compare whether it was mostly pace, tone or urgency. Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder), Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) and the 90-second daily check-in are free on the site.

A limit to keep in mind: These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking things through ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When

someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A pause is for both of you. If one person is never allowed to pause, or a "pause" is used to punish with days of silence, that isn't retuning. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs).

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works
How meaning, tone and listening work — read online

Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system
Why stress speeds people up or shuts them down — read online

Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words
How you like to be spoken to — read online

Part Three · Chapter 9 · Minds that work differently
When pace and tone are a wiring difference — read online

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 1
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

The 90-second daily check-in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in

II

PART TWO · CHAPTER II

Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home

One gentle question: can the way you share the work keep going, or is one of you quietly running on empty?

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Look at the month, not last night
2. Three things go in
3. Balance: how the hours split
4. Ownership: does each job have a name?
5. Stress: how full each stress tank is
6. One number comes out, from 0 to 1
7. Start with the biggest shortfall
8. It judges the setup, never a person
9. Words this chapter uses
10. On your own: is your own load working?
11. One setup, looked at twice
12. Common mix-ups
13. Small children and a new baby
14. If only one of you wants to try this
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Look at the month, not last night**, using what you both wrote down.
- **Three things go in**, which are how the hours split, whether each job has a name, and how full each person's stress tank is.
- **One number comes out, from 0 to 1.** Start with whichever part pulled it down most.
- **It judges the setup, never a person**, and it is where a talk starts.

ANY GIVEN WEEK

One of you is quietly doing eleven small things a day that the other has never had to think about: the bin rota, the fish food, the reply to the school, the dentist reminder, the bit of the shopping list that says "bulbs?". When the other says it feels even, they mean it. From inside their own week, it does.

01

Look at the month, not last night.

When people ask whether the split is working, the answer usually comes from whatever happened most recently. This chapter asks a calmer question, using what you both wrote down. Ask it again every few months, even when things seem fine, because a split that worked once can quietly go stale.

Two housemates had one truly awful week of dishes in May, the kind where you wash a fork to eat with it. The whole month, written down, showed three ordinary weeks and one exam week, which changes the conversation completely. Put a short check in your calendar for about a month from now.



SUGARFOOT

One bad evening isn't the whole story. Give it a month, then run the check together, slowly, with something to eat.

TOOL **Fair split check: this week** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working

02

Three things go in.

The first is how evenly the hours are shared. The second is whether every regular job has a clear owner, from the job list in One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job). The third is how stressed each of you already is from everything else going on. A **workpaper** is one of the site's free fill-in worksheets. You don't need any of them to start; rough notes on the back of an envelope work too.

YOU COULD SAY

"Let's each bring our own numbers, so neither of us has to guess."

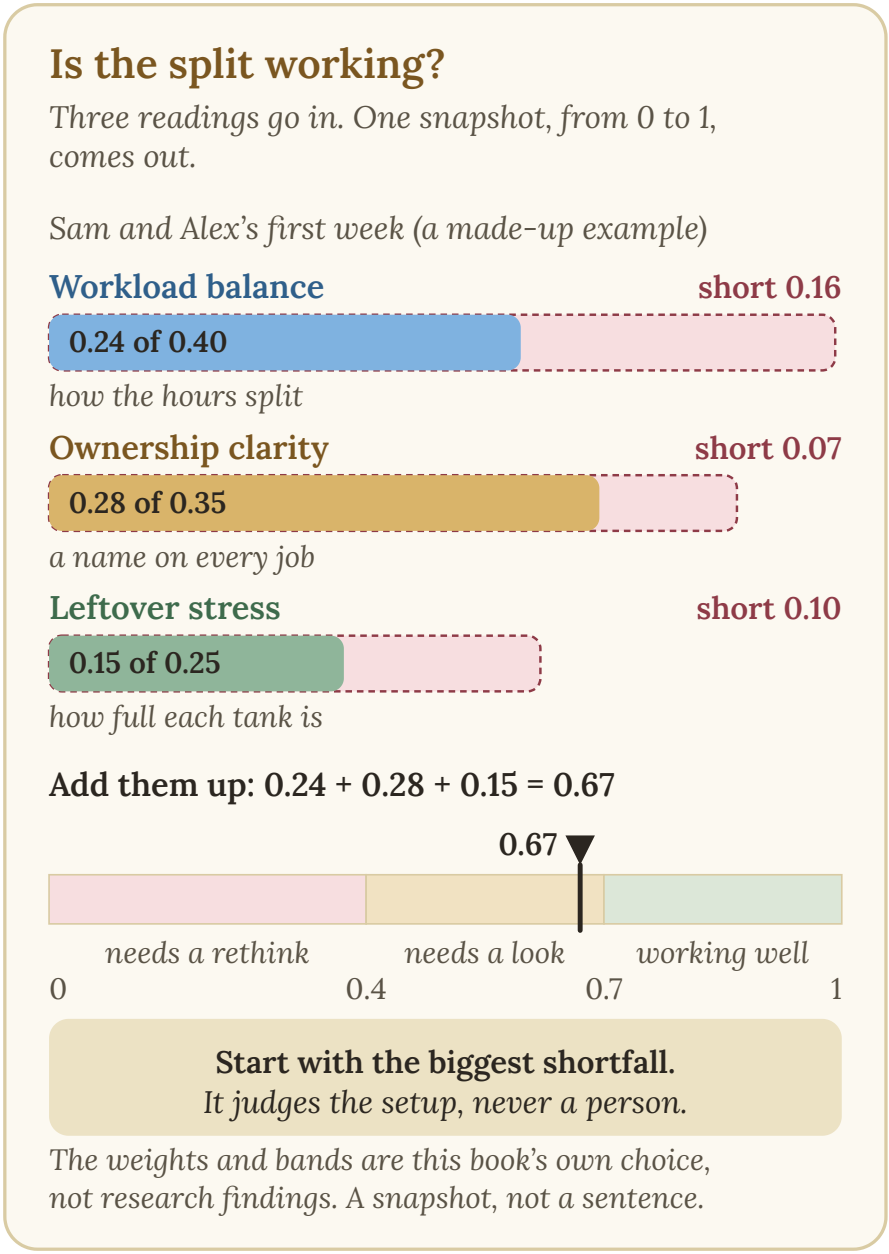


FIGURE 7 Is the split working? Three readings go in and one snapshot comes out. Start with the biggest shortfall. It judges the setup, never a person.

03

Balance: how the hours split.

From your week-long logs, work out each person's share of the hours. An even split scores 1 and one person doing everything scores 0, whichever person it is. If you have agreed an uneven split that suits you, perhaps because one of you works longer hours outside the home, compare against that split instead. With three or more of you, compare each person's share with an even share (100 divided by the number of people) or with the split you agreed. Three partners who log 30 hours of home jobs between them, at 15, 9 and 6, would each have 10 as an even share. The "Who does what?" page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand), where each person lists their hours, does the arithmetic for you.

Log one week each, and include the small jobs that take under ten minutes. Those are the ones that go missing.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

Who does what? Quick look

Wren, Josh and Mei, housemates (Wren's view)

Quick look: who does what at home

Mark who mostly does each job. The picture builds as you go, the thinking work too.

Your name
Wren

Their name
Josh

Person 3
Mei

Job	Who mostly does it
Dishes	*Shared*
Laundry	*Shared*
Cleaning the bathroom	*Josh*
Cooking dinner	*Mei*
Grocery shopping	*Wren*

Job	Who mostly does it
Paying bills	*Wren*
Noticing what's running low	*Wren*
Planning the week	*Mei*
Remembering dates and appointments	*Wren*

HOW IT LOOKS

Here's how it looks from your side, 9 jobs so far.

Everyday jobs: mostly shared. 6 jobs: Wren 2 · Josh 1 · Mei 1 · Shared 2.

Planning and remembering: mostly Wren. 3 jobs: Wren 2 · Mei 1.

The thinking work is easy to miss, because nobody sees it happen. Saying it out loud is a good start.

Does this match how it feels to the three of you?

Made-up example. Pets and booking appointments were taken off the list: they don't happen in this house.

Fill in your own: Who does what? Quick look (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand)

04

Ownership: does each job have a name?

Each job gets two names. The owner does the job from start to finish, and the backstop notices if it slipped and checks in gently, which is very different from supervising. It can be the same person, though a second name gives the job a gentle check. Count the jobs that have an owner and divide by all the jobs on the list, and leave the jobs nobody owns on the list, because they matter most. A *decision* you make together, such as which school, can be marked "Both (decide together)" and counts as owned, while a *job* that needs doing gets one name.

This one comes almost straight from my old job. In audit work, most of the failures I saw weren't incompetence. They were unclear ownership: work that belongs to everyone belongs to no one, and it quietly lands on whoever

notices first. Two sisters care for their dad, and nobody owned his repeat prescription, so for a fortnight each of them thought the other had ordered it. He ran out on a Sunday.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"Can we put a name next to this one, so it doesn't fall between us?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

A job without a name tends to land on whoever notices first. Write one owner next to each job, and the guessing stops.

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03

05

Stress: how full each stress tank is.

Each of you rates how full your own stress tank is with How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying), where a higher score means more stress. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 is medium, and 0.60 or more is high. The score uses the average of your two scores, but if either of you is at 0.60 or more, talk about that first, even when the overall result looks fine. A setup that only works when you are both well rested can't last, so more stress lowers the result. A grandmother raising two grandchildren scores 0.70 while her son, who helps at weekends, scores 0.35. Her 0.70 is the headline, whatever the average says. Each of you scores your own tank on the same day, before looking at the other's.

06

One number comes out, from 0 to 1.

A result of 0.70 or above reads as *working well*, meaning the setup is holding. From 0.40 up to 0.70 it reads as *needs a look*, because something is drifting, often who owns what, and below 0.40 it reads as *needs a rethink, together*. The result is called the setup score. It is a simple weighted sum, in which the hours count most, then the owners, then stress, and although it looks like a probability it isn't one. Two friends who run a café together score 0.55, which tells them nothing is broken and something is drifting; it turns out to be the

Monday ordering, which both of them assumed the other did. Write the date next to your number, so you can compare next month.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

Is the setup working for everyone?
Rosemary and Ken, retired, married 41 years

Is the setup working for everyone?

Person 1 (optional)
Rosemary

Person 2 (optional)
Ken

1. How the hours split

From Who did what or the "Who does what?" page: each person's total hours for the week.

Rosemary, hours
14

Ken, hours
10

2. Does each job have a name?

From One owner per job.

Jobs on the list
12

Jobs with an owner
9

3. How much each person is carrying

Each person's own score from How much are you carrying? Everyone fills in their own.

Rosemary, load (0 to 1)
0.45

Ken, load (0 to 1)
0.30

HOW THE SETUP IS WORKING

Working well
0.75 of 1. The setup is carrying its own weight.

Next: nothing in the setup needs changing this week. Keep the same rhythm of check-ins.

If you want to nudge it higher one day (optional, not urgent): hand about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken, and balance would go from 0.83 to 1.00. Give one more job an owner (the person who does it and sees it through), and ownership would go from 0.75 to 0.83.

It scores the setup, never a person, and never the relationship as a whole.

Fill in your own: Is the setup working for everyone?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/calculators/is-the-setup-working-quick)

07

Start with the biggest shortfall.

The single number matters less than which of the three parts pulled it down most. The **shortfall** is how far one part fell below the most it could add, and in the middle band it is often ownership, which is why the calculator suggests One owner per job first. Separated parents score 0.62 and find that their biggest gap is that nobody owns the school forms, so that is the only thing they change this month.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"Which part pulled the number down most? Let's start there."

08

It judges the setup, never a person.

The number isn't a verdict on who's better or whether the relationship works. It's where a conversation starts, never how one ends. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor

on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

One partner sees 0.35 and says, "So I'm the problem." The other says no, the bathroom has no owner and he works nights, and they start there. Before you begin, agree that either of you can say "pause" and come back later.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. The score describes the setup you share, but your levers are your own: your jobs, your hours and what you agree to take on. You can propose a fix; you can't make the other person accept it. If the balance stays one-sided, step your load back towards your share on purpose, and say so kindly. Matching effort with effort protects your stress tank, and your tank is part of the score too. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

SUNDAY EVENING

Two week-long logs and two cups of tea on the table. One list has 31 rows. The other has 18. For a moment nobody says anything, and the fridge hums. Then one of you says, "I honestly didn't know about half of these."

Words this chapter uses

A **log** is a simple list of the jobs you did this week and roughly how long each took. The **owner** does a job from start to finish, including remembering it, and the **backstop** notices if a job slipped and checks in gently. Your **stress tank** is how much stress you are already carrying from the rest of life. The **setup** is the way you share the work right now, which can always be changed, and the **setup score** is the one number from 0 to 1 that sums up the three readings. Invisible jobs count too. Planning meals, remembering birthdays, booking the vet and noticing that the soap is running low all belong in your log.

On your own: is your own load working?

You can ask the same question about your own week, which is whether you are spending more energy than comes back. Add up what you carry, jobs and worries both, and set it beside what refills you. If it runs in the red, change your side by dropping, delaying, asking or saying no kindly. A limit describes your supply, and it says nothing about your worth. After a breakup, Leanne has her children every other week and fills the quiet weeks with favours for friends, including one memorable flat-pack wardrobe. Writing it down shows her she never rests (more in On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'd love to help, and I can't this week. Can I let you know next week?"

One setup, looked at twice

Three people share a flat above a bakery, and everyone agrees that cleaning matters while nobody owns the bathroom. Their first check scores 0.67, and the biggest shortfall is ownership: eight of the twelve jobs have a name, and the bathroom, the bins, the recycling and the hallway don't. They give each of those four jobs an owner and a backstop. A month later, with the hours and their stress tanks about the same as before, the score is 0.79. Ownership went from 0.67 to 1.00, and that part counts for 0.35 of the score, so it adds 0.12. The bathroom is better and the recycling is still a sore point, because the one who owns it works late on collection night, and that is the job they talk about next. Shift work, illness and caring can all make hours look even while sleep or energy is not, and an uneven split agreed on purpose can be the fair one (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours, and When one of you is ill, spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

Our room agreement

Kayla and Bea, first-year roommates

Our room agreement

Your name
Kayla

Their name
Bea

Quiet hours
11 pm to 7 am on weeknights, midnight on Fridays and Saturdays. Headphones after that.

Guests (daytime)
Fine with a quick text first. Not during the other one's study or sleep time.

Overnight guests
Up to 2 nights a week, agreed the day before. A guest doesn't stay in the room when their host isn't there.

Cleaning
Kayla: floor and bins, Sunday. Bea: desk area and the fridge, Wednesday. Our own laundry, our own job.

Borrowing
Ask first, every time. Food on the shared shelf is for both of us.

Lights and alarms
Big light off by 11:30 on weeknights; a desk lamp is fine. One alarm, one snooze at most.

How we bring up problems
Text first if that's easier, then talk within a few days, one topic at a time. If we're stuck, we ask our RA to help.

YOUR AGREEMENT, READY TO SEND

Our room agreement (Kayla and Bea), with every line above, ending: "We'll look at it again together in a month."

They kept most of the site's starting point and changed two lines.

Fill in your own: Our room agreement (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)

Common mix-ups

A low number doesn't mean the relationship is failing. It means the current setup needs changing, and setups change all the time. Please don't guess the numbers; a guessed number is a feeling with a decimal point, so use your written logs. One of you can't fill it in for both, either. Each person writes their own log and scores their own stress tank. And fair doesn't have to mean exactly 50/50. Fair is what you both agree to with your eyes open, and an uneven split you chose together can be the fair one. Two kinds of fair (page 76) looks at this.

Small children and a new baby

Small children bring a flood of new jobs, and most of them are thinking jobs, such as the nursery bag, the jabs, the party invitations, the next size of clothes and the night wakings. That is why the mental load (see the work nobody sees, page 27) often grows after a baby arrives, usually without anyone deciding it. Log the children's jobs too, with the thinking time, and count the nights. Hand over whole jobs, such as the clothes and sizes or the GP and the jabs, so that the new owner does the noticing too, in their own way. If a baby is on the way, write your first job list together before the birth, plan the nights and agree to look again at six weeks, at three months and before either of you goes back to work. In the first weeks, share by energy more than by hours, so that whoever was up in the night gets the rest.

Hollie and Gareth have Alfie, who is three, and Poppy, who is eight months old, and Gareth is a paramedic on shifts. Their logged minutes come out

nearly even, yet Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked for. They leave the minutes alone and move one whole job, the children's clothes, to Gareth.

YOU COULD SAY

"Could you own the nursery bag from now on, including noticing when we're low on nappies? I won't check it."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

Who did what, with small children

Hollie and Gareth, parents of a toddler and a baby; Gareth works shifts

Who did what

Person A
Hollie

Person B
Gareth

Week beginning
12 October 2026

Part A: Who did what, this week

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Mon	*Pack the nursery bag: spare clothes, nappies, named milk*	*Hollie*	10	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Book Poppy's one-year jabs at the GP*	*Hollie*	15	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Bath and bedtime, both children*	*Gareth*	45	*Asked for*
Wed	*Reply to a party invite and buy the present*	*Hollie*	25	*Noticed and handled*
Wed	*Sort outgrown clothes and order the next size*	*Hollie*	40	*Noticed and handled*

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Thu	*Plan the week's meals around Gareth's nights*	*Hollie*	*20*	*Thinking and planning*
Thu	*Cook dinner and batch-cook for the weekend*	*Gareth*	*75*	*Noticed and handled*
Fri	*Remember the nursery photo money and form*	*Hollie*	*10*	*Thinking and planning*
Fri	*Night wakings with Poppy*	*Hollie*	*60*	*Noticed and handled*
Sat	*Swimming lesson with Alfie*	*Gareth*	*60*	*Asked for*
Sat	*Big food shop and nappies*	*Both*	*80*	*Asked for*
Sun	*Washing for both children, to put away*	*Hollie*	*50*	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Fix the stair gate*	*Gareth*	*20*	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Update the family calendar and the childcare rota*	*Hollie*	*20*	*Thinking and planning*

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

Hollie
290 minutes (55%), of which 250 noticed and handled without being asked (50 of them thinking and planning)

Gareth
240 minutes (45%), of which 95 noticed and handled without being asked

Workload balance score
0.91. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

Unasked-for work
Hollie did 72% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no

Left blank this week.

Gareth worked three night shifts this week, so his rows are fewer; the minutes are close, and the noticing is the part to talk about.

Fill in your own: Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01)

If only one of you wants to try this

That is common, and you can still start. Log your own week, score your own tank and then share one small thing you noticed, without asking the other person to agree with your numbers. A dad noticed he was spending five hours a week driving his sixteen-year-old to training and back, said so without any accusation, and they agreed on a bus pass for two days a week. His son grumbled for a fortnight and then started enjoying the bus. Share one finding at a time and then let it rest for a few days.

If the other person refuses to talk about the split at all, ever, or makes you feel afraid for raising it, that isn't a setup problem. Please read Not safe at

home?

More for your situation

Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together) · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

To run the check, each of you first logs one week in Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01), because the number only means something if you each wrote your own. Next, fill in the job list in One owner per job together, including any jobs nobody owns yet, and each score your own stress tank on the same day. Put the three numbers into the calculator (spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working), look first at the biggest shortfall, pick one small change together and check again in a month.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees
The unseen work the check counts
page 18

Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles
The stress input, explained
page 61

Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change
Fixing the setup with small, kind changes
read online

Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well
When one person carries the care
read online

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 2: give every job one owner
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job

III

PART TWO · CHAPTER III

Full tanks and different angles: stress and perspective

Why some reactions are bigger than what caused them, and why two people can see the same moment so differently.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. A full tank overflows
2. Some stress is left over from earlier
3. Check your stress tank in a minute
4. Three everyday states
5. There are seven angles on the same moment
6. Both views can be true
7. Say it instead of making each other guess
8. A full tank means "later," not "never."
9. Words this chapter uses
10. On your own: reading your own tank
11. Common mix-ups
12. Two homes: co-parenting after a split
13. If only one of you wants to try this
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **A full tank overflows**, so stress left over from earlier makes small things feel big.
- **Check your tank in a minute**, and say the band out loud so nobody has to guess.
- **Two people can see one moment from different angles**, and both views can be true.
- **A full tank means later**, so pause, name a time and come back.

THURSDAY, 5:15PM

They ask, perfectly pleasantly, whether you remembered to call the dentist. Your answer comes out about four sizes bigger than the question deserved, with a bit about the car thrown in, and you can hear it happening while it happens.

01

A full tank overflows.

If you're already tired or stretched from somewhere else, a small question can get a big reaction, which is simply human. Anything decided in that moment is worth coming back to once you have both calmed down. A nurse gets in at eight in the morning after a night shift, and her housemate, eating cornflakes, asks whether she saw his message about the electricity meter. She bites his head off. Twelve hours on her feet did the biting; the meter just came at the end of them.

YOU COULD SAY

"Sorry. That was bigger than the question. I'm running on empty."

02

Some stress is left over from earlier.

Ask yourself how much of this feeling is about the thing in front of you and how much you brought in with you. Being upset about the dishes and being exhausted, with the dishes as the thing you noticed, are different problems. Some of what we bring in is much older, such as an understanding from growing up that whoever notices the mess has to clean it, and if a feeling seems a lot older than the moment, Where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up) helps you find where it started.

A fourteen-year-old has a horrible day at school, the kind he won't talk about, comes home and explodes because his brother has taken the phone charger. Again. The charger was the last drop in a tank that was already full at lunchtime.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

“I think I brought this in with me. Give me ten minutes.”



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Before a hard talk, check how full your own tank is. Five quick questions, about two minutes, and you’ll know whether now is the time.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

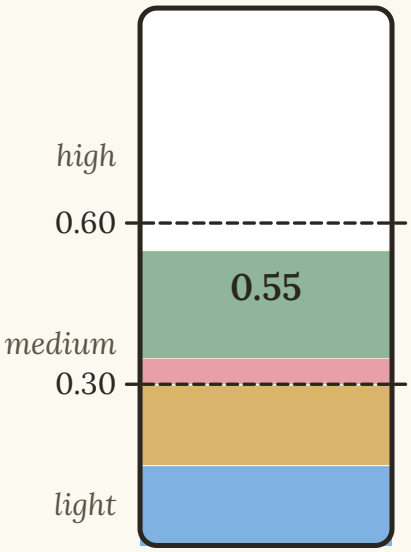
03

Check your stress tank in a minute.

How much are you carrying? measures how full your stress tank is, and a higher score means more stress in the tank. Score five things from 0 to 4, which are sleep, work elsewhere, any unsettled argument, how your body feels and time pressure today, then add them up and divide by 20. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 is medium and 0.60 or more is high. If it has been high for a long time it can start to feel normal, so a quick reading each week is worth it. A man caring for his wife after her hip operation scores 0.65 three days in a row. That tells him something he hadn’t let himself think, which is that he needs help more than he needs to try harder. He rings his son that evening. Score yourself tomorrow morning, before you look at your phone.

How full is your stress tank?

Score five things from 0 to 4. Add them up, divide by 20.



Sam today

Time pressure today	4
Body: hungry, unwell, in pain	0
Unresolved conflict	1
Workload elsewhere	3
Sleep debt	3
11 ÷ 20	**= 0.55**

Medium: say it before a hard talk.
"Heads up, I'm carrying more than usual today."

Made-up example from this chapter. The five items and bands are this book's, not a tested questionnaire.

FIGURE 8 How full is your stress tank? Five things scored 0 to 4, added up and divided by 20. The scores shown are an example; the items and bands are this book's.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

How much are you carrying?

Rosa, who shares her mum's care with her brother

How much are you carrying?

Fill this in on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it in for someone else.

Your name
Rosa

Date
7 October 2026

The checklist

0 = Not at all · 4 = Very true

Sleep debt (less rested than usual)

0 1 2 (3) 4

Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving)

0 1 2 3 (4)

Recent unresolved conflict (any source)

0 (1) 2 3 4

Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain)

0 1 (2) 3 4

Time pressure today specifically

0 1 2 (3) 4

YOUR STRESS TANK

Your stress tank today
High (13 out of 20 points)

What to do
Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour. If you need to settle first, the Calm-Down Kit is made for this.

If it can't wait
If what you're carrying can't wait, like caring for someone who is ill, that's a sign to get more help, not to try harder: ask one person for one specific thing this week, and look into respite care.

Filled most by
sleep debt, workload elsewhere, time pressure today. Conditions, not character.

Stress tank score
0.65 out of 1.00

Optional

☑ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

Anything you want to name before talking
Mum's hospital appointment moved to Thursday, and I'm the one driving.

Made-up example. Higher means a fuller stress tank. Rosa scores only herself; her brother fills in his own.

Fill in your own: How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02)

04

Three everyday states.

Knowing whether you are calm and connected, revved up or running on empty tells you whether now is a good time to talk. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks), a thirty-second self-check, helps you make a best guess. The labels come from polyvagal theory, whose main claims are still debated by scientists, and here they are used

only as everyday words. In one long-distance couple, he takes the video call at midnight his time and is usually running on empty by then, so they move the hard talks to Saturday mornings. It helps to know one body clue for each state; a tight jaw is a common one for revved up.

05

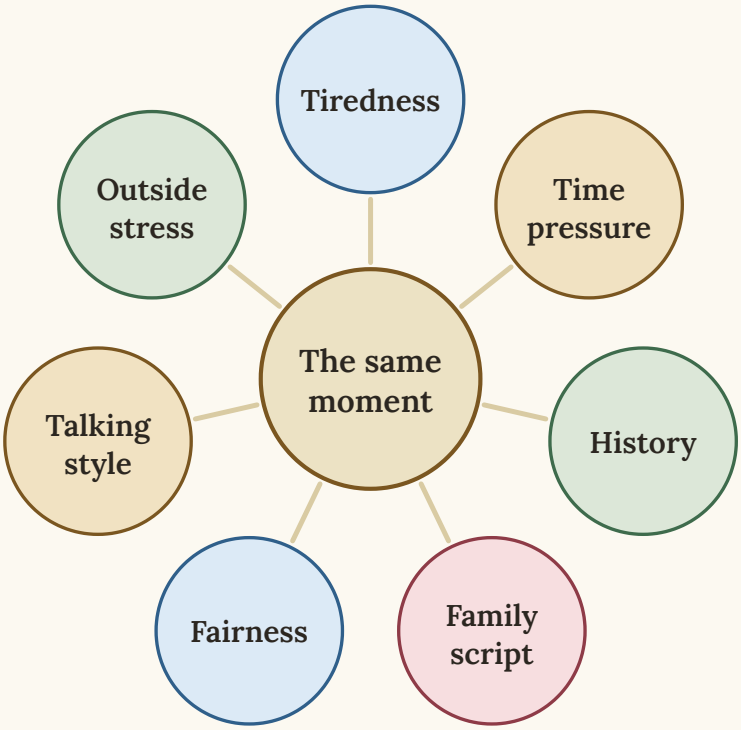
There are seven angles on the same moment.

The seven angles are tiredness, time pressure, history, what home was like growing up, your sense of fairness, how you communicate and stress from outside. Many arguments are two people looking from different angles, each sure that the other sees what they see. The "See their side" step of Rewind the talk (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder) is built on these seven angles and helps you picture how the same moment might look from the other side, with questions to ask in place of guesses. Planning Christmas, one parent sees it from family habit (they always go to her mum's, and there's a stocking with each child's name on it) and the other sees it from fairness, since they went there last year too, and the year before.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "Which angle are you seeing this from?"

Seven angles on the same moment

Which one are you looking from right now?



An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict.
Name your own. Ask about theirs.

Illustration. The seven angles are this book's; the Rewind the talk's "See their side" uses them.

FIGURE 9 Seven angles on the same moment. An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict: name your own, and ask about theirs.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

Rewind the talk: see their side

Hana, about her friend Lou

See their side

1. What happened?

I asked Lou if she was still coming to my birthday dinner, and she just replied "maybe".

2. Who are they to you?

Partner Family Roommate *Friend* Coworker Co-parent

My teen or child Someone else

3. What state might they have been in?

Calm and connected Revved up *Running on empty* I'm not sure

4. What might have been going on around them?

A long or hard day *Little sleep* Rushed or late Money worries

Caring for someone Not feeling their best A noisy or crowded place

Other people were there *It was a text or message* It was late at night

5. How are they wired?

They notice tone a lot They take words literally *They need time to process*

They think out loud They're very direct They hint rather than say

They like a plan Noise, light or crowds get to them

Their language or culture differs

6. What history might they carry?

This has come up before They grew up with it done differently

It's a sore topic for them They may feel it's unfair

7. What could each of you see? They may have seen or known things you didn't

their whole day and workload *a message, call or news you didn't see*

something they had already planned or done how it looked from where they stood

a promise someone else made them how they were feeling inside

You may have seen or known things they didn't

the planning you had already done · *the reason behind your timing*

what you actually meant · how tired or stretched you were · the part already done

a deadline only you knew about

Neither of you could fully see

each other's tone, in writing · what was going on in the other's head

what would happen next · what other people had said to each of you

THROUGH THEIR EYES

Running on empty: If they were running on empty, short replies and slow answers are what a tired body does. It can look like not caring when it's only having nothing left.

Caring for someone: Caring for someone else uses up attention you can't see. They may have had less to give than usual.

Questions to check, instead of guessing: "How was your day, before this came up?" "Would it help to think about it and come back to it later?"

A sentence to bridge the gap: "I think we may have been seeing this from different places. On my side, I knew about the reason behind my timing, and I'm not sure that came across. I'm wondering whether, for you, you were running on empty. Could we compare notes? I'd like to understand how it looked to you."

These are possibilities to check, not facts about Lou.

Fill in your own: Rewind the talk: see their side (spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder)

06

Both views can be true.

You can each be right about what you see and still be looking at different parts of the same thing, so the useful question is which angle each of you is seeing it from. Two adult brothers argue about their late mother's house. One sees thirty years of memories, the height marks on the kitchen door

frame, the apple tree. The other sees a roof that needs £9,000 of work. Both of them are looking at the real house.

WORDS TO TRY

"You're right about what you see. Can I tell you what I see?"

07

Say it instead of making each other guess.

Before a hard conversation, each of you says how full your stress tank is and which angle you are seeing things from. It works best at the start. Two colleagues begin a tense meeting about a missed deadline with one sentence each about their tank and their angle. It feels a bit odd. The meeting is shorter and calmer than the last one, and nobody cries in the toilets afterwards.

YOU COULD SAY

"Before we start, I'm about half full today, and I'm seeing this from the time angle."



TIDBIT

Say your number out loud, as in "I'm about a seven today." It takes two seconds, and nobody has to guess.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

08

A full tank means "later," not "never."

A high score is a reason to pause and never a way out of the talk. Say when you will come back, and let the Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) help in the meantime. After your calming steps, check your tank again. Under 0.50, go back at the time you said. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round if you still feel hot, and if you are still at 0.60 or more after two rounds, pick a new time and say when. A dad and his fourteen-year-old get heated about phone time. He tells her he's too wound up and will talk at seven. At seven he knocks on her door, which matters more than anything he says once he's inside.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I need a break. I'll come back at seven. I promise."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. Your stress tank is the only one you can empty. You can't calm someone else's tank for them, and pouring yours into theirs leaves two empty tanks. Protect yours: rest, say "later," and give energy where it's met. When both tanks are full, the kindest thing you control is the timing. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

MONDAY MORNING

You both look at the same pile of post on the kitchen table, eleven envelopes and a pizza menu. One of you sees a to-do list, and the other sees proof that nobody else ever opens the post. You try saying your angles out loud, and it helps for about a minute before the old argument about the gas bill comes back. The pile is still there at lunchtime, and neither of you has decided whose it is.

Words this chapter uses

Your **stress tank** is how much stress you are already carrying before this moment even starts. **Leftover stress** is the part of a feeling you brought in from somewhere else, like poor sleep or a hard day, while **this-moment stress** is caused by what is in front of you right now. An **angle** is the point of view you are seeing a moment from, such as tiredness or fairness.

On your own: reading your own tank

On your own, the most useful habit is a one-minute reading of your tank before you react. Check it for a few mornings in a row and look for a pattern, ask yourself before a hard moment how much of it is left over from earlier, and decide on a calm day what settles you so that it is ready when you need it. Living alone after a breakup, Bryony noticed that she snapped at her sister on the phone every Monday. Her morning readings

showed why: Sunday nights were her worst sleep of the week, every week. Now she asks for Tuesday instead (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

Common mix-ups

A big reaction sometimes means it was a big deal. Quite often it means the tank was already full. A high score is never an excuse, either; it's a note to come back later, never a pass to skip the talk. You can't tell how full someone else's tank is, however well you know them, which is why each person scores only themselves. And a pause isn't the silent treatment, because a pause has a time to come back. That's why you always say when.

Two homes: co-parenting after a split

Children carry two homes, and changeover day fills their tank, so being quiet, clingy or cross for a few hours after a handover is common and usually says nothing bad about the other home. It helps to give them landing time, with a snack, something familiar and no questions about the other home for the first hour. The child is never the messenger, because adult news goes adult to adult. For money, follow any formal arrangement. Split the extras by a ratio you agree, and settle up once a month from one list. With an ex, share the band and keep the story, as in "I'm in a heavy week. Could we swap Wednesday?", and your private life stays yours. If an ex won't cooperate but isn't dangerous, parallel parenting can work, with written messages only, short and business-like, handovers at school and your own list for your own home. When there are new partners, the parent stays the owner of anything involving the other home, and a step-parent starts as a friendly adult rather than the one who tells the children off.

Harriet gives Freya, who is eight, and Arlo, who is five, an hour of toast and blankets when they come back from their dad's, and she has stopped asking what happened at Dad's at the front door. Sunday evenings are calmer, though Arlo still cries at bedtime on changeover days, and she is waiting to see whether that eases.

WORDS YOU COULD USE (A BUSINESS-LIKE MESSAGE)

"Hi Dylan. Freya's school trip is on 6 November and costs £24. I've paid it and put it on the extras list. Thanks, Harriet."

If you are afraid of your ex, a shared plan isn't the right tool: see Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

If only one of you wants to try this

You can do all of this on your own side, by checking your own tank, naming your own angle and pausing and coming back on time. The other person doesn't have to use the words for it to help, and when one person starts saying it out loud, the other often starts to as well. A daughter visits her dad every Sunday, and every week they clash over his health. She starts each visit by saying she is a bit tired today, so if she goes quiet it isn't about him. He never scores anything himself, and still the visits get calmer, and one Sunday he says, unprompted, "I'm a bit tired today as well, love."

A note on safety: A full tank explains a reaction. It never excuses shouting, threats or hurting anyone. If someone's "stress" often turns into fear for you, that isn't a tank problem. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If sharing how you feel ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? lists free, private hotlines.

More for your situation

Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Long distance

(spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room) · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

Before your next hard conversation, score the five things in How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying), add them up and divide by 20, then say one sentence out loud about your tank and your angle. If either of you scores 0.60 or more, put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour, and agree on a time to come back.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system
The ladder, flooding and rest — read online

Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other
The angles and stories behind a reaction — read online

Part Three · Chapter 13 · Anger
What to do in the hot minutes — read online

Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words
Checking your own weather first — read online

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 3: notice how much each of you is carrying
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying

IV

PART TWO · CHAPTER IV

Two kinds of fair: equal vs fair at home

Agree on what "fair" means before you argue about it, and give a comment a moment to land before you answer it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. There are two kinds of fair
2. Fair by results
3. Fair by promises
4. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner
5. Covering is kind. Say it out loud
6. Let a comment land before you react
7. Notice, name, decide
8. Keep the two questions apart
9. On your own: your own kind of fair
10. Common mix-ups
11. Money between you
12. A couple and a housemate
13. More for your situation
14. A note on safety

IN SHORT

- **There are two kinds of fair**, by results (did it all get done?) and by promises (did each of us do what we agreed?), so agree which one you are using.
- **Once a job has an owner, look to the owner**, and when you cover for someone, say so out loud.
- **Let a comment land before you react** by noticing it, naming it and then deciding what to say.
- **Keep the two questions apart**, because whether the job was done is a fact and whether the comment hurt is a feeling.

THE SAME ARGUMENT, TWICE A MONTH

One of you counts hours. The other counts who noticed that the job needed doing in the first place. You're both counting honestly, in two different currencies, and then arguing about the exchange rate, usually on a Sunday evening, usually about the oven.

01

There are two kinds of fair.

One kind asks whether everything got done, and the other asks whether each person did what they said they would. Both are reasonable, and friction starts when each of you is using a different one without realising. Nisha and Kezia share a room in halls. Nisha thinks a week was fair if the room is tidy by Friday, whoever tidied it. Kezia thinks it was fair if each of them kept her own half clean. For most of the first term they each think the other is being unreasonable, and neither of them is.

YOU COULD SAY

"When you say fair, do you mean it all gets done, or that we each do our bit?"

Two kinds of fair

Both are reasonable. Trouble starts when you use different ones without saying so.

Fair by results

Asks: Did it all get done?

Guards: Will the home keep running?

Good: flexible. Watch: it can hide who always steps in.

- Bins ✓
- Dentist ✓
- Forms ✓

Fair by promises

Asks: Did each of us do what we agreed?

Guards: Can I rely on you?

Good: clear. Watch: it can feel rigid in a hard week.

- Bins · Sam ✓
- Dentist · Maya ✗
- Forms · Lin ✓

The agreement: look to the owner

Bins · owner: Sam
second name: Alex, who notices and asks once

Once a job has a named owner, judge it by whether the owner did their part (swapping or asking ahead counts), not by whether someone quietly covered. Made-up examples.

FIGURE 10 Two kinds of fair. Both are reasonable; trouble starts when people use different ones without saying so. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

02

Fair by results.

This kind of fair judges by outcomes, by whether the right things got done by whoever had the time or energy. It is flexible and easy-going. Done carefully it counts the cost to whoever covered, and done carelessly it can hide who is always stepping in. A grandmother raising her grandchildren has a grown-up son who helps with whatever is needed when he's home, cheerfully and well. The house runs. And she is always, always the one who notices what is needed. For one week, mark every job you picked up that wasn't planned; the tally is often a surprise.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

Who does what? The Money tab

Grace and Ruth, a couple with different incomes

Money (optional)

One line per cost. Put what each person actually paid.

Currency
£ (pounds)

Bill	Grace paid (£)	Ruth paid (£)	How it's shared
Rent	1,100	700	*Shared, split*
Power and water	160	0	*Shared, split*
Internet and phones	0	90	*Shared, split*
Groceries	300	250	*Shared, split*

	Grace brings in (£)	Ruth brings in (£)	How it's shared
Pay	4,200	2,800	*Money coming in*

THE SUMMARY

Each person's total: Grace £1,560; Ruth £1,040.

Coming in: £7,000 (Grace £4,200, Ruth £2,800). After shared bills: £4,400 left.

Two ways to split the shared bills. Split evenly: Ruth would put in £260 more · Split by income (60/40): it already comes out even. Pick whichever feels fair to you.

Even isn't always the fair answer (incomes and rooms differ), so treat this as a starting point, not a verdict.

Made-up example. Money is a fair topic only where nobody controls the other's money.

Fill in your own: Who does what? (Money tab) (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand)

03

Fair by promises.

This kind asks whether each person did the jobs they agreed to own. It is clear and steady, and it can feel rigid in a week when life gets in the way. Two business partners run a café. One owns the ordering, the other owns the staff rota. When the rota is late (it's the Thursday before a bank holiday, it's always late then) they ask the rota owner about it, rather than "the team", and nobody takes it personally.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"It's my job, and I can't do it this week. Could you take it, and I'll take the bins?"

04

Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

The owner is the person who does the job from start to finish. A second name on the list is a backstop, who notices if it slipped and checks in gently without supervising, and it can be the same person. If the job is yours, the question is whether you did it, and somebody quietly covering

for you doesn't answer it. That protects the person who keeps filling the gaps. In one stepfamily the thirteen-year-old owns feeding the dog and his stepmum is the second name. When the bowl is empty at seven, she says "Dog's dinner?" once, without doing it for him and without a lecture.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 10

One owner per job

Dee and Mark, foster carers

One owner per job: caring for a child in care

Person A
Dee

Person B
Mark

Date of this list
4 October 2026

The split you agreed (optional)
Dee works three days; Mark works full time

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Social worker visits	*Monthly*	1.5	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Mark joins by video when he can*
Reviews and meetings	*As needed*	2	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Dee books and preps; Mark comes to the big ones*
Daily log and placement paperwork	*Daily*	0.5	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Mark writes it on Dee's work days*
Contact visits and calls with their family	*Weekly*	1.5	*Mark*	*Dee*	*Saturday mornings*
School liaison (designated teacher, plans)	*As needed*	1	*Dee*		

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Being there after contact	*As needed*	1	*Mark*	*Dee*	*Quiet tea, no questions*
Health and therapy appointments	*As needed*	1.5	*Dee*		
Training and support group	*Monthly*	2	*Mark*		*Mark's turn this term*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
8 of 8. Every job has an owner.

How the jobs are spread
Counted by how often each job comes round, and by size or time where you gave it: Dee 61% · Mark 39%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Dee works three days; Mark works full time". Does this match it? It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

☑ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)
Dee and Mark

"Being there after contact" is on the list because hidden work counts.

Fill in your own: One owner per job (caring for a child in care)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

05

Covering is kind. Say it out loud.

Helping out when the owner can't is lovely, and it helps to mention it, so that the help is seen, as in "I put the bins out this week, since you were away." Help that stays silent turns into unseen work, and unseen help slowly becomes expected (see Complacency, spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency). Two grown-up sisters take turns driving their dad to his appointments. When one covers for the other, she texts the same day:

"Took Dad on Thursday, you were on lates. All fine, bloods normal." It takes ten seconds and it stops the help from going invisible.



SUGARFOOT

Covering for someone is kind. Say that you did, gently, and ask for what you'd like next time, so it doesn't turn into quiet resentment.

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

06

Let a comment land before you react.

When a remark hits harder than it should, say "Give me a second." The idea is borrowed loosely from brain science, where the brain turns down sounds and sensations automatically in a fraction of a second, while this pause is a few seconds you choose to take on purpose. Let the spike pass, then decide whether the remark needs an answer now or later, or at all. A nurse comes down at two in the afternoon after a night shift and her husband says, "Oh, you're up." She hears "at last". She says she needs a second because she's very tired, and it turns out he meant he was glad to see her and had saved her the last of the soup (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours). Agree your own "give me a second" phrase today, while things are calm.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a comment stings, give it a minute to land before you answer. This workpaper is a short check for your reply.

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09

07

Notice, name, decide.

First notice that a comment landed hard, then name it kindly, as in "That hit harder than you probably meant," and once you have settled, decide how to reply. Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) helps with the words. A fifteen-year-old tells her dad that he never listens. He feels his chest tighten. He says that stings, and that he wants to hear her properly, and he decides it needs a real talk,

the next evening, after her swimming, in the car, which is where they talk best.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> “I want to answer that, just not this minute. Can we talk at eight?”

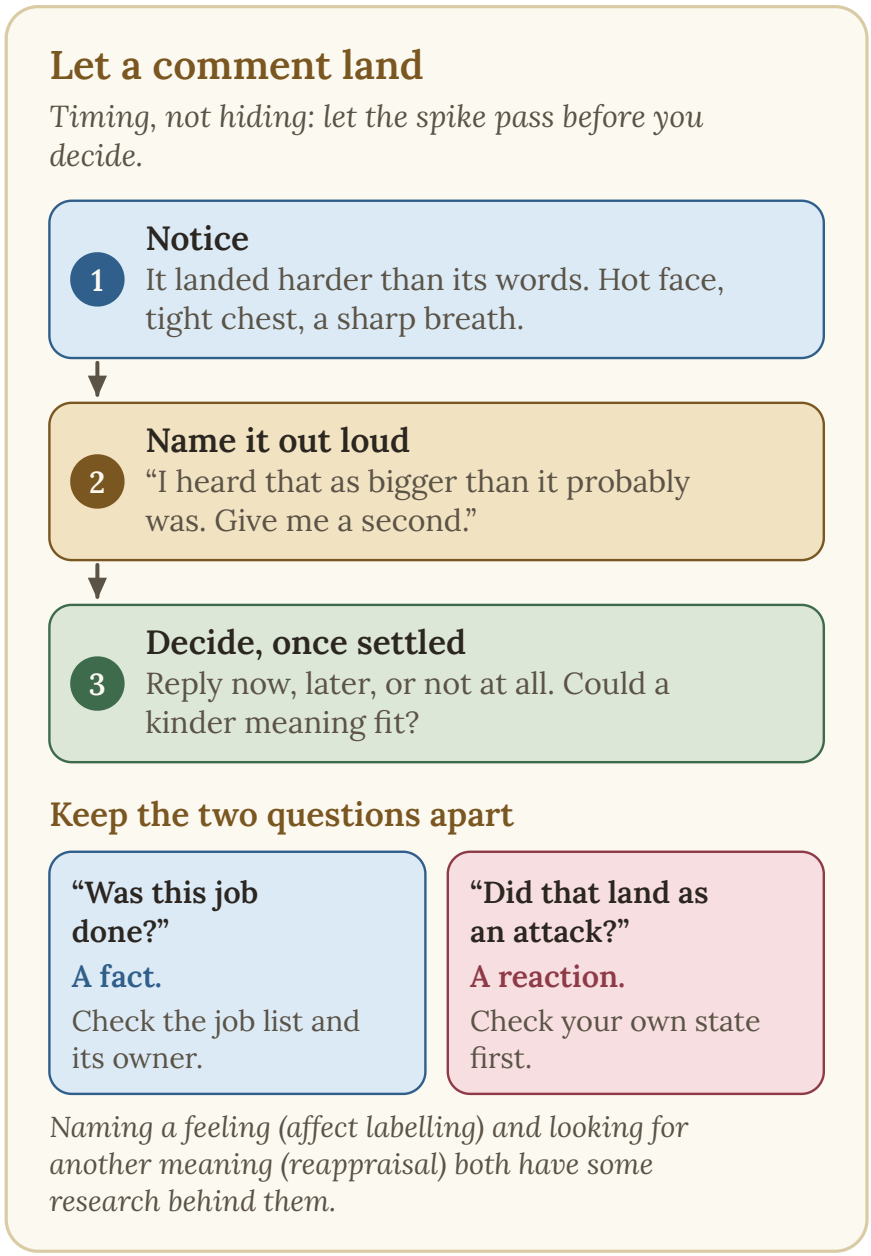


FIGURE 11 Let a comment land before you react: notice, name, decide. And keep the fact question apart from the feeling question.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 11

Say it so it lands

Carla, who runs a café with her business partner Femi

Say it so it lands

Your name
Carla

Date
8 October 2026

Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Raw reaction
Great, so I'm doing the stock order on my own again.

What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.)
The stock order for the café wasn't placed by Tuesday noon, and I placed it at 4.

What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…)
I felt stretched thin, and a bit alone with it.

What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?)
Could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?

Before you react: four quick checks

Is this about a specific, nameable task or event?

(*Yes*) No

Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot?

Yes No (*Not sure*)

Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said?

(*Yes*) No

Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation?

(*Their words*) A past pattern

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ways to say it

Quick one, no rush: could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?

Suggestions

Your own stress tank is part of how this reads. A few hours, or a night's sleep, often changes how it reads. There's a kinder reading that also fits. Try asking about it first: "Did you mean ___, or ___?"

The raw reaction stays on the sheet, not in the message.

Fill in your own: Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09)

08

Keep the two questions apart.

Whether the job was done is a question about a fact, and whether the comment hurt is a question about a feeling. Both matter, and each goes better in its own conversation. Separated parents share their children across two homes, and the bag comes back without the school shoes, along with a text about it that felt cold. They sort out the shoes first and talk about the text on Sunday (see Co-parenting, spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting). When a talk tangles, "Fact or feeling?" is a good question to ask out loud, and then you finish one before starting the other.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control whether, when and how you bring something up, and whether you cover a job out loud. How the other person responds is theirs. If you cover again and again with no thanks and no change, match the energy: cover less, and say so kindly. Fair by promises only works when both people keep theirs. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

THE WEEKLY CATCH-UP

Sam and Alex share a home. Alex owns the bins but works late on Tuesdays, and Sam has quietly taken them out three weeks running. At the catch-up Sam mentions it, and Alex admits that Tuesday nights aren't realistic with the late shifts. They agree to try a swap for the rest of the month, with Sam taking the bins and Alex taking the recycling and the weekly grocery order, and to settle it at the monthly look-back in Chapter V (page 92).

WEDNESDAY, 7PM

"Thanks for doing the dishes," one of you says, a little flatly. It was meant as a thank-you. It sounded like a criticism. Before you know it you've replied to the criticism, and the person who said thank you is now defending a thank-you.

On your own: your own kind of fair

Fair starts with knowing what it means to you and which jobs are truly yours. Write down what fair means to you in one sentence, and list the jobs you own alongside the ones you picked up without ever agreeing to. Olu lives alone and has his children every other weekend. His sentence, after some crossing out, is that fair means not doing their jobs for them just because he misses them (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). Pick one job you took on without agreeing, and either keep it on purpose or raise it on a calm day.

Common mix-ups

If it got done, there may still be a problem, because someone may be paying for it in time and energy. Holding the owner to the job isn't being strict; it's keeping the agreement you both made, which is kinder than quiet resentment. Letting a comment land doesn't mean ignoring it. It's about timing, and you still get to answer. And please don't save up months of covering to bring out all at once. A long list lands like a bill. Mention covering as it happens.

Money between you

Money is where the two kinds of fair meet most often. Some couples put everything into one pot. Some keep their money separate and pay agreed bills, often half each, which is fair by promises, the same rule for both. Others each pay into a shared pot in line with what they earn and keep the rest, which is fair by results, since each is left with a similar share. Many couples mix them, with a joint account for bills and food and some money each that nobody has to explain. The right way is the one you both chose with your eyes open. To talk about it, start with your money stories, how money worked at home when you were growing up, then move on to the numbers and to a "talk first" amount for big purchases that applies to both of you. A limit you both chose and both keep is care, not control.

Niamh takes home £2,600 a month and Tariq £1,900, and their rent and bills will be £1,500. They split it 58/42, in line with their pay, so she pays £870 and he pays £630.

> WORDS TO TRY
>
> "Can we each say how money worked in our families growing up?"
> "Would half each, or in line with our pay, feel fairer to you?"

A couple and a housemate

A couple sharing a home with a housemate who isn't a partner is a different shape from three equals. It helps to keep two lists, **house jobs** for all three of you, such as the bins, the bathroom, the bills and the landlord, and **couple jobs** for the two of you. Decide house questions with all three of you there, rather than in bed the night before, hear the housemate first on anything that affects them, keep couple arguments out of shared rooms and never ask them to referee. Ollie and Hamza share a flat with their friend Bex. They split the rent by room, since the couple has the bigger one, and the bills by person, and all three hold a short house meeting on the first Sunday of the month, with biscuits, which Bex insists is the only reason she comes.

YOU COULD SAY

"That's a house question. Let's decide it when Bex is here."

More for your situation

Each of these pages takes the ideas in this chapter into one kind of relationship. Start from your relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists them all.

- Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · More than two partners (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room) · Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together)
- Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- Different hours · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Two faiths (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · On my own

On a calm, easy day, each of you can say which kind of fair comes more naturally, results or promises. Then pick three regular jobs and write an owner for each in the job list in One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job), with a second name for someone who notices if it slips. Finally, agree a short phrase for when something lands hard, such as "Give me a second", along with the promise that the person who asked for a second will come back to it.

A note on safety

These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about what's fair ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A promise is something both people chose and either can ask to change. Rules one person sets for the other, with checking, punishment or money held back, are control, and that is not your fault. See normal limits and control (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together#control).

WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH SOMEONE YOU TRUST

"Things at home don't feel fair, and I'm scared to bring it up. Can I talk it through with you?"

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt
Repair and apologies that land — read online

Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works
Letting words land before you reply — read online

Part Three · Chapter 10 · Values, meaning and a good life
Fairness as a value you choose together — read online

Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture
How a group's norms decide what feels fair — read online

PUT IT TO USE



Six-week program, week 4: talk about it kindly
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



Say it so it lands
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands

V

PART TWO · CHAPTER V

The monthly look-back: a calm relationship check-in

Once a month, look back for the problems that keep coming back, and fix the setup instead of having the same argument again.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Weekly check-ins miss patterns
2. You need four weeks of notes and one list
3. Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped
4. A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner
5. Sort each repeat into one of three kinds
6. Count the gaps each month
7. Look back even when nothing is slipping
8. It's not a review of either person
9. Keep it short and kind
10. A look-back, three months in
11. Common mix-ups
12. Starting out: before you move in
13. Raising a grandchild (kinship care)
14. More for your situation
15. On your own: a monthly look at yourself

THE THIRD TUESDAY IN A ROW

The bins again. You could have the same ten-minute back-and-forth about Tuesday that you had last Tuesday, word for word, or you could notice that this has now happened three Tuesdays running and wonder what it is about Tuesdays.

01

Weekly check-ins miss patterns.

One missed job looks like bad luck. The same job missed week after week is a pattern, and patterns are easiest to see when you look at the whole month. The look-back is a careful, friendly glance over that month, closer to a self-check than an inspection.

Four flatmates had an overflowing bathroom bin every week, and every week it seemed like bad luck, until they looked at the month together and saw it had happened every single week since September. In my old job the step that got skipped more than any other was going back afterwards to check that the fix had actually held, and skipping it is exactly how the same problem turns up again three years later. This chapter is that step, made small. Choose a monthly date now, the last Sunday, say, and put it in everyone's calendar.

02

You need four weeks of notes and one list.

Bring the month's four weekly notes from Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01), where a few lines a week is enough, and your job list from One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job). Twenty minutes is usually enough. If either of your stress tanks is high that day, at 0.60 or more on How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying), move it a day or two. A couple on different shifts keep their weekly notes in one shared note on their phones and do the look-back on the one evening a month they're both off, with a takeaway, which has become the part they look forward to.

03

Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.

A job slipped if it was noticed and not done, only done after being raised more than once, or quietly covered by someone who isn't its owner. Look closely at every job with two or more ✗, because three or four in a month is a real pattern. Two foster carers find the reading log was missed three weeks out of four. They mark the ✗ in pencil, together, before either of them explains anything, which is harder than it sounds and much the best order.

04

A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner.

Such a problem gets patched every week and never fixed. The owner is the person who does the job from start to finish, so the fix is to give the job one owner whose name sticks, or to talk honestly about whether anyone has the time and energy for it. In a home with three partners, “whoever’s free” does the online grocery order, and it was late three times this month. With nobody owning it, everybody assumed someone else had it. One Friday there was no milk at all, and four jars of mustard.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 12

One owner per job: a list for two homes

Laura and Dan, co-parents in two homes

One owner per job: a list for two homes

Person A
Laura

Person B
Dan

Date of this list
1 October 2026

The split you agreed (optional)
Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Pack the handoff bag	*Weekly*	*Laura*	*Dan*	*Laura keeps the checklist and the spare kit; whoever hands over packs from it*
Send medicine and chargers with the bag	*Weekly*	*Laura*	*Dan*	*Inhaler: write the last dose time on the card*
School forms and permission slips	*As needed*	*Dan*	*Laura*	
Reply to school emails and apps	*Weekly*	*Dan*		*Dan reads them Sunday night*

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Kids' doctor and dentist visits	*As needed*	*Dan*		*Dan books; tells Laura the date*
Homework help (Laura's weeks)	*Daily*	*Laura*		
Homework help (Dan's weeks)	*Daily*	*Dan*		
Activities and sign-ups	*As needed*	*Dan*	*Laura*	*Swimming and Cubs*
Buy clothes as they outgrow them	*As needed*	*Laura*		*Receipts in the shared folder*
Big decisions (school, health, new activities)	*As needed*	*Both (decide together)*		*A decision, not a job: Dan puts it on the list; talked through by phone, never at handoff*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
10 of 10. Every job has an owner.

How the jobs sit across the homes
Counted by how often each job comes round (a daily job about five times a weekly one): Laura's home 52% · Dan's home 47% · Together 1%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5". Does this match it? Two homes rarely split evenly, and that can be fair: weekdays and weekends, distance and work all play a part.

Made-up example. If one parent is afraid of the other, a shared list isn't the right tool: see Not safe at home? on this site.

Fill in your own: One owner per job (two homes) (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

05

Sort each repeat into one of three kinds.

If a job has no clear owner, update the job list. If its owner can't keep up, have a kind, honest talk. If there was a short-term cause, like a bout of flu, note it and move on. Separated parents looking at the missed homework folder ask whether nobody was sure which home signs it, whether one of them is swamped, or whether it was simply the week she had flu (see Co-parenting, spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting).

The monthly look-back

Which gaps kept reopening, however often we closed them?

1 Mark the month

	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
Recycling	✕	✕	✕	✕
Bins	✕	✕	·	✕
School forms	·	✕	·	·
Dog's walk	·	·	·	·

The ✗ goes next to a job, never next to a person.

2 Sort each repeat

Structural gap
No clear owner, or the wrong name on the list. → **Update the job list.**

Capacity issue
An owner who has run out of room. → **Set a time for a kind talk.**

One-off
A clear short-term reason: illness, travel. → **Note it and move on.**

3 Count, and close the month

Fewer structural gaps over several months is a good sign. Zero isn't the goal.

Short and kind. A look at the setup, not a review of either person.

This book's own method, adapted from team "retrospectives"; it hasn't been tested as a household method.

FIGURE 12 The monthly look-back: mark the month, sort each repeat, count and close. The cross goes next to a job, never a person.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 13

What keeps coming back?

Ash, Robin and Jules, a triad sharing a home

What keeps coming back?

Person A
Ash

Person B
Robin

Person C
Jules

Month
September 2026

Part A: Gather the month's notes

Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped. ✗ = it slipped that week.

Task	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Times flagged
Cat litter	✗	✗		✗	3
Recycling out on Thursday		✗	✗		2
Book Jules's car service			✗		1
Shared calendar kept up to date	✗	✗	✗	✗	4

Part B: Sort each gap

Sort every task flagged twice or more.

Task	Named owner on the job list?	Classification	Action
Cat litter	No	*Structural gap*	*Robin owns it, with Ash as backup; on the one-owner list tonight*
Shared calendar kept up to date	Yes	*Capacity issue*	*Ash owns it but is on nights this month; talk on Sunday about what comes off Ash's list*
Recycling out on Thursday	Yes	*One-off, no action*	*Two bank holidays moved the day*

PART C: WRAP UP THE AUDIT

Structural gaps found

1. Update One owner per job for each of these in this session.

Capacity issues found

1. Set a time for the conversation. This audit brings it to light, but it doesn't replace it.

One-offs

1

Part D (optional): Thanked, or only noticed when it's missed?

Job	Gets thanked	Only noticed when missed?	One way to notice it
Keeping the calendar	*Rarely*	*Yes*	*Say thanks at Sunday dinner when it's up to date*
Topping up the cat food	*Never*	*Yes*	*A note on the fridge*

A task with no owner is a gap in the setup, not a verdict on the person who kept covering it.

Fill in your own: What keeps coming back? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04)

06

Count the gaps each month.

Write down how many gaps of each kind you found. If the number of jobs with no clear owner falls over several months, the setup is working, and a single month can be a normal swing. If it keeps rising, something bigger has changed and it is worth a talk. Two business partners write their monthly count on a whiteboard in the back office, next to the fire-drill notice. In March four jobs had no clear owner. By June, one did, and they argue cheerfully about whose fault that one is.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The look-back has its own workpaper: a month of notes, one list, and an ✗ for each week a job slipped. It makes a pattern easy to see.

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04

07

Look back even when nothing is slipping.

A month with no gaps is good news, and it is also the month most likely to go unchecked. When something has worked for a while, people stop looking, and nothing breaks on the day that happens. Keep the look-back going in quiet months and add one question, "*What's something we've stopped noticing or mentioning*?", which is how a look-back guards against complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency). The children have left home and nothing at all is slipping. At the look-back one of them says, quietly, that they don't really talk at dinner any more. No list would have shown that.

08

It's not a review of either person.

You don't add up old hours or punish old mistakes. You can thank someone for what they carried before, and you leave the past unbilled. The only question is where the setup isn't working yet and what you will try next month. After a month in hospital, one partner comes home to a long list of what slipped. They thank each other for what each carried, and set up the month ahead, and that's all.



TIDBIT

A look-back can start with something that went well. Name it first. The weekly card has a nice way to begin.

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins

09

Keep it short and kind.

Start with something that went well and talk about the job instead of the person. If a gap needs a proper talk, set it for another day using Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins). If a talk starts going badly, either of you can call a pause, and whoever paused names a time to come back. A mum and two teenagers hold their look-back over pizza on the last Friday. Each says one good thing first (the younger one's is always "the pizza"), one gap gets a new owner, and it's over in fifteen minutes.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 14

Kitchen-table check-in: this week

Linda and her grown-up son Jordan, who live together

Our weekly check-in

Week of Oct 5 · Linda and Jordan

Who's checking in (optional)
Linda and Jordan

One thing that went well
Jordan cooked twice, and we ate together on Thursday.

One thing that felt heavy
The bathroom, again. And Mum's back was bad all week.

One small thing to try next week
Jordan owns the bathroom on Saturdays. Linda stops checking it.

Our next check-in
Sunday after dinner

Any jobs that slipped or came up again this week? (optional)

Dishes · Laundry · Trash and recycling · Groceries · Cooking · *Cleaning the bathroom* · Paying the bills · Planning and remembering

ON THE CARD

One topic at a time. We're on the same side. Tick a job once it has one owner.

Fill in your own: Kitchen-table check-in: this week (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. In the look-back you can only fix the gaps you own, and offer help with the rest. You can't make someone keep a rhythm. Keep the rhythms you can keep, notice which ones are kept in return, and let your effort follow: more where it's shared, less where it isn't, so the rhythm doesn't run on one person's energy. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

THE LAST SUNDAY OF THE MONTH

Two mugs of tea, four weeks of notes, twenty minutes. You go down the list together. Most weeks went fine. Two jobs keep coming up, the recycling and the call to the landlord about the window, so you give each of them a name and finish your tea while it's still warm, for once.

A look-back, three months in

Sam and Alex's bins slipped three weeks in a row because Alex works late on Tuesdays. After the trial swap they make it official, so Sam owns the bins and Alex takes the recycling and the weekly grocery order, which keeps the hours even. The second month is clean. In the third, the grocery order slips twice, both times in a week when Alex's mother was in hospital, and they mark it as a one-off and leave the list alone. What changes in month three is that Alex mentions, almost in passing, that he has stopped enjoying their Saturday mornings, which no list had shown, and they agree to talk about it properly on Thursday.

YOU COULD SAY

"I don't think anyone dropped this. I think nobody ever picked it up."

Common mix-ups

This isn't where you settle who owes what. Past hours are never billed to anyone, though you can still say thank you for them; you only fix the setup going forward. A slipped job doesn't mean its owner failed, either, because the gap might be in the list, or in the owner's capacity, or in one strange week. And you can't skip the weekly notes and just do this. The look-back only works if the weekly notes feed it.

A note on safety: These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If looking back together ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A look-back is something you both choose. If one person demands logs of the other's every hour, checks their phone without agreement, or uses the ✗ marks to punish, that is control, not a look-back, and it is not your fault. See Not safe at home? and normal limits and control (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together).

Starting out: before you move in

If you are new together and about to share a home, the tools work best now, before habits set, at about one step a week. In the first week, each of you writes down the rulebook from the home you grew up in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up) and then you swap, with curiosity. In the second, talk about money, starting with your money stories and moving on to the split (Chapter IV, page 89). In the third, write your first job list, with one owner per job and the thinking jobs included (One owner per job, spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03), and in the fourth,

make a pause plan (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw) on a calm day. In the fifth, each name three things that matter most to you about a home (Part Three, Chapter 10, spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-10-values). After the move, log one ordinary week once two weeks have passed, and do your first short look-back after four. None of it is a test, and the point is that neither of you has to guess.

Niamh and Tariq, eight months together, find that their families meant different things by "tidy", and they agree on the kitchen every night and the rest on Sunday.

Raising a grandchild (kinship care)

Many grandparents and other relatives raise a child whose parents can't, and much of it involves things that keep coming back, such as cancelled calls and the hard evenings after contact. A monthly look-back helps. Some repeats you can own, and some, like a parent who misses calls, you can't, and for those you can own the plan for the evening after. The child may love both the parent who can't look after them and you, so tell them they don't have to choose, and don't run the parent down in front of them. Explain an absent parent in short, true words that fit their age, always with the message that it isn't their fault. When the parent is your own adult child and things are hard between you, keep messages about the child short and civil for the child's sake, and leave the door open. Look after yourself too. Ask for respite, and find other kinship carers. In England and Wales, the charity Kinship (kinship.org.uk) can help.

Maureen, who is sixty-three, is raising her grandson Tyler, who is nine. Her look-back shows that his mum's Sunday call fell through three times this month, so she plans those evenings with hot chocolate and his football annual, and asks her brother to take Tyler swimming on Sunday afternoons.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH THE CHILD
>
> "Mum loves you. She isn't well enough to look after you right now, and that's not your fault."

More for your situation

A look-back works in every kind of relationship, with small changes. Start from your relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists pages for each one.

- More than two partners (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two) · Money together · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship) · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Kids grown and gone (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest)
- Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Two faiths (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

On your own: a monthly look at yourself

Once a month, look back at your own month kindly, more like a weather report than a scorecard. Ask what filled your battery and what drained it, which of your limits held and which slipped, and choose one small thing to keep and one to change. Gillian lives on her own after a divorce, and her look-back shows the same ✗ three weeks running: she skipped her Thursday swim to answer work emails. So she moves the emails to Friday morning and keeps the swim (see On my own).

To begin, put a relaxed twenty-minute date in the calendar once a month and keep your weekly notes somewhere you can both find them. At the look-back, start by naming one thing that went well, and end by writing down how many gaps of each kind you found, so that over the next few months you can see whether the number is falling. What keeps coming

> back? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-04-what-keeps-coming-back) is the workpaper for that conversation.

That's the end of Part Two. The book goes on in Part Three: Understanding people (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings), chapters on how people work, for anyone. To put Parts One and Two into practice first, try the six-week program (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01): six gentle weeks, with one chapter and one small tool each week.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Weekly check-ins miss patterns.
- ✓ Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.
- ✓ Sort each repeat into one of three kinds.
- ✓ Look back even when nothing is slipping.
- ✓ Keep it short and kind.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part One · Next · Who you are becoming — read online
The same kind look, on your own

Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change — read online
Why problems come back, and how habits stick

Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working? — page 44
The setup score the look-back feeds

Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt — read online
Repairing what the look-back finds

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 6: make it last
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

What keeps coming back? A monthly look-back
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-04-what-keeps-coming-back

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool this book points to, in two separate lists, with the chapters and pages that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-01 **Who did what** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-01
In: The work nobody sees (page 18), Is the split working? (page 44), The monthly look-back (page 92)

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02
In: Is the split working? (page 44), Full tanks and different angles (page 61), The monthly look-back (page 92)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03
In: Is the split working? (page 44), Two kinds of fair (page 76), The monthly look-back (page 92)

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04
In: The monthly look-back (page 92)

WORKPAPER WP-09 **Say it so it lands** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-09
In: Why we get out of tune (page 31), Two kinds of fair (page 76)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 61)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13
In: Why we get out of tune (page 31)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder
In: Why we get out of tune (page 31), Full tanks and different angles (page 61)

TOOL **Kitchen-table check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins
In: The monthly look-back (page 92)

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins
In: Two kinds of fair (page 76)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 61)

TOOL **Rhythms side by side** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/frequency-calibration
In: Why we get out of tune (page 31)

TOOL **Who does what? Quick look** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand
In: The work nobody sees (page 18)

TOOL **Who does what? Count the hours and bills** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand
In: Is the split working? (page 44), Two kinds of fair (page 76)

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 61)

TOOL **My weather today: the sky (the ladder)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks
In: Why we get out of tune (page 31), Full tanks and different angles (page 61)

TOOL **Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting
In: Is the split working? (page 44), Full tanks and different angles (page 61), Two kinds of fair (page 76), The monthly look-back (page 92)

TOOL **Plan it once: room agreement for roommates** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room
In: Full tanks and different angles (page 61), Two kinds of fair (page 76), The monthly look-back (page 92)

TOOL **Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/work
In: Is the split working? (page 44)

TOOL **Fair split check: this week** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/is-the-setup-working
In: Is the split working? (page 44)

How the numbers work

Every number in this book is arithmetic you can do with a pencil. None of them is a test, a diagnosis or a verdict on anyone: they describe a week, a load or a way of sharing work. The weights and cut-offs are this book's own rules of thumb, not research findings, and you are free to disagree with them. The worked examples are the book's own, so you can check them against the chapters.

Two habits run through all of them. **Scores are rounded to two decimal places before their band is read,** so the number you see and the words you see always agree. And **nobody's score is ever worked out for them:** if someone's own answer is missing, the total waits.

The stress tank: How much are you carrying?

You score five things from 0 (not at all) to 4 (very true), about the last day or two: sleep debt, workload elsewhere, unresolved conflict, your physical state, and time pressure today.

```
tank = (sleep + workload + conflict + body + time) ÷ 20
```

The answer runs from 0 to 1, and **higher means fuller**. Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 up to 0.60 medium, and 0.60 or more high. (The worksheet splits each band in two for its words: very light under 0.15, light, medium on the lighter side under 0.45, medium on the heavier side, high under 0.80, and very high from 0.80.) Your **battery** is the other side of the same thing, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery. The battery is a picture in words, not a second score.

> WORKED EXAMPLE Rosa, from Part Two, Chapter III, page **61**, scores sleep 3, workload 4, conflict 1, body 2 and time 3.
>
> `3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 = 13; 13 ÷ 20 = 0.65`, which is in the high band.

Two or more of you: each person scores only themselves, and the shared figure is the plain average of everyone's own scores. If any one person is at 0.60 or more, treat that as the headline, whatever the average says.

Coming back after a pause (the Calm-Down Kit): if you like numbers, take the score again after a calming round. Under 0.50, go back at the time you named. From 0.50 to 0.59, take another round. At 0.60 or more after two rounds, put it off to a named

time. The kit's line sits at 0.50 on purpose: you don't need an empty tank to come back, just one less than half full.

My weather today: the room in your day

My weather today shows words, not numbers: a sky (clear, gusty or fogged in) and how much room you have today. Behind the words sits a rough tally from 0 to 100, where **higher means a heavier day**. You only see it if you tick "Show the numbers behind this".

WHAT YOU PICKED	ADDS
The sky: clear, gusty, fogged in	0, 26, 34
The pressure: light, building, heavy (skipped: 6)	0, 10, 20
Last night's sleep: properly rested, about enough, short night, barely slept (skipped: 6)	0, 2, 10, 18
People load: barely any, a normal amount, a lot, nonstop (skipped: 4)	0, 3, 9, 14
Ground conditions (hungry, thirsty, in pain and so on)	4 each, up to 14
What's blowing in (work, money, health and so on)	3 each, up to 10

Under 45 reads as lots of room today, 45 to 64 as some room, and 65 or more as very little room.

> WORKED EXAMPLE Joel, from Part One, Now (online), picks gusty, building pressure, a short night, a lot of people time, one ground condition (hungry) and one thing blowing in (work).
>
> `26 + 10 + 10 + 9 + 4 + 3 = 62`: some room today, with less than usual, so the forecast says to go gently and settle first.

Workload balance: how evenly the hours are shared

Two people. Work out each person's share of the logged hours as a percentage.

```
balance = 1 − (the difference between the two percentages ÷ 100)
```

50/50 scores 1.00; one person doing everything scores 0.00. It doesn't matter which of you does more. Balance ignores the total, which is one reason the stress

tank sits beside it.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary logs 14 hours and Ken 10 (Part Two, Chapter II, page 44). Out of 24 hours, that is 58.3% and 41.7%.

`1 − (58.3 − 41.7) ÷ 100 = 1 − 0.167 = 0.83`

Three or more people, or an agreed split. The same idea, said more generally: how much of the week would have to change hands to reach the target, compared with the most that ever could.

```
each share = that person's hours ÷ everyone's hours
target     = an even share (1 ÷ number of people), or the split you
agreed
moved      = ½ × the sum of every |share − target|
most       = 1 − the smallest target share
balance    = 1 − moved ÷ most
```

WORKED EXAMPLE Three partners log 15, 9 and 6 hours (Chapter II, page 44): shares 0.50, 0.30 and 0.20, against a third each.

`moved = ½ × (0.167 + 0.033 + 0.133) = 0.167; most = 1 − 0.333 = 0.667; balance = 1 − 0.167 ÷ 0.667 = 0.75`. In hours, 0.167 × 30 = 5 hours a week would change hands for an even split.

With an agreed split, use it as the target: co-parents who agreed 60/40 and log 12 and 8 hours score 1.00.

Ownership: does every job have a name?

```
ownership = jobs with a named owner ÷ all the jobs on the list
```

The calculator counts a job as owned when it has one named owner. A backstop, the person who notices if it slipped, is a good habit and has its own column, but the score only needs the owner. The starter jobs on the worksheet don't count until you give them an owner or change them. Never raise the score by deleting the jobs nobody owns: they are exactly what the score is there to show.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken list 12 regular jobs, and 9 have an owner: `9 ÷ 12 = 0.75`.

Who carries more of the list. A score of 1.00 can still mean one person owns everything, so One owner per job also shows each person's share of the list, with each job weighted by how often it comes round and how big it is:

```
weight of a job = how often × size
how often: daily 5, weekly 1, ongoing 1, monthly 0.25, as needed 0.1
size:      small 0.5, medium 1 (the default), big 2
           (or, where you gave the hours each time: hours ÷ 0.5)
share      = the weights of that person's jobs ÷ the weights of all
the jobs
```

A job you decide together counts the same for each of you; on a list for two homes it shows as "Together" instead.

WORKED EXAMPLE One person owns the cooking (daily, medium: 5) and the bills (monthly, medium: 0.25). The other owns the laundry (weekly, big: 2) and the car (as needed, medium: 0.1). Each owns two jobs, but `5.25 ÷ 7.35 = 71%` of the list's weight sits with the first person, and 29% with the second.

Who's carrying more right now. Who did what flags the busiest person when their share of the logged minutes (or of the work done without being asked) is at least half, and at least 20 points over an even share: 70% or more for two people, 53% or more for three. In the example in the Preface, page **18**, one partner did 105 of the 115 minutes that were noticed and handled without anyone asking: 91%, so the sheet says so.

The setup score: can the way you share the work last?

```
setup score = balance × 0.40
            + ownership × 0.35
            + (1 − the average tank score) × 0.25
```

The weights add up to 1, so the score runs from 0 to 1, and here **higher means the setup is working better**, the opposite of the tank score. The tank is the only part that counts against the score, which is why it enters as 1 − tank. 0.70 or more reads as working well (the "Who does what?" page says "holding"); 0.40 up to 0.70 as

needs a look ("drifting"); below 0.40 as needs a rethink, together. It is a snapshot of the setup, never a probability and never a verdict on anyone.

WORKED EXAMPLE Rosemary and Ken (Chapter II, page 44): balance 0.83, ownership 0.75, and their own tank scores are 0.45 and 0.30, an average of 0.375.

`0.83 × 0.40 + 0.75 × 0.35 + (1 − 0.375) × 0.25 = 0.333 + 0.263 + 0.156 = 0.75`: working well.

The shortfall is what each part could have earned minus what it did earn: balance 0.40 − 0.333 = 0.067; ownership 0.35 − 0.263 = 0.088; tank 0.25 − 0.156 = 0.094. The biggest shortfall is the tank, which usually eases outside the chore list (more sleep, a lighter week elsewhere). The calculator's "what would help most" is the single change with the biggest gain: handing about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken would take balance from 0.83 to 1.00, worth 0.067. Naming one more job's owner would be worth 0.029, and a tank score lower by 0.10 on average 0.025.

The overall score adds a fourth part, retuning: of the moments that landed badly this week, how many you retuned before answering.

```
overall = balance × 0.35 + ownership × 0.30 + (1 − tank) × 0.20 +
retuning × 0.15
(no rough moments this week: leave retuning out, and divide the first
three parts by 0.85)
```

In Chapter II's first worked example (balance 0.60, ownership 0.80, an average tank score of 0.40, and 3 of 5 rough moments retuned): `0.21 + 0.24 + 0.12 + 0.09 = 0.66`.

The 30-day look-back: what shifted this month?

The look-back splits the last 30 days into four weeks (the first takes the first ten days). For each part you filled in (balance, ownership, the stress tank, and last-minute rescues), it compares the start of the month with the end:

```
start = the average of weeks 1 and 2
end   = the average of weeks 3 and 4
it shifted if end − start is 0.10 or more (balance, ownership, tank),
           or 1 a week or more (rescues); anything smaller didn't
shift
```

One next step: a part that moved the wrong way comes first (the biggest move for its size). Otherwise, the first of these that is still true at the end: ownership under 0.70, balance under 0.70, 2 or more rescues a week, or anyone's tank at 0.60 or more. If none is, keep the same rhythm and look again in 30 days.

Hours to change hands over the month: for each person, the hours they did minus their share of everyone's hours, added up week by week. Half the sum of those gaps (ignoring the minus signs) is how many hours would change hands to make the month even.

WORKED EXAMPLE Suppose Rosemary and Ken keep going for a month (made up, like them). Their four weeks: hours 14 and 10, 15 and 9, 13 and 11, 12 and 12; jobs with an owner 9, 9, 11 and 11 of 12; Rosemary's tank 0.45, 0.50, 0.40, 0.35 and Ken's 0.30 every week; rescues 3, 2, 1, 1.

PART	START (WEEKS 1–2)	END (WEEKS 3–4)	CHANGE	READS AS
Balance	(0.83 + 0.75) ÷ 2 = 0.79	(0.92 + 1.00) ÷ 2 = 0.96	+0.17	Better
Ownership	0.75	0.92	+0.17	Better
Average tank score	0.39	0.34	−0.05	About the same
Rosemary's own tank	0.48	0.38	−0.10	Lighter
Rescues a week	2.5	1	−1.5	Fewer

Three of the four parts shifted, all for the better, and nothing is left on the watch list, so the next step is to keep the rhythm. The setup score went from 0.73 to 0.87. Over the month Rosemary did 54 hours and Ken 42, so 6 hours would have changed hands for an even month.

On your own: is your week sustainable?

The “Who does what?” page’s “just me” view adds up the hours your week is spoken for (jobs, the thinking work, care and so on) and compares them with a waking week of about 112 hours (16 waking hours, 7 days).

```
share = the hours spoken for ÷ 112
```

Under 50% reads as sustainable, 50% up to 70% as full but workable, and 70% or more as stretched. For example, 50 hours spoken for is 45%, which leaves real room; 80 hours is 71%, a lot to keep up week after week.

All of these are this book’s own ways of putting things into numbers. They have not been tested in research studies, and they shouldn’t be quoted as findings. The free calculators on the website do the arithmetic for you, and each one has a “How is this worked out?” note.

Blank worksheets

Photocopy or print these pages, as many times as you like, and fill them in by hand. Each one is a blank copy of a worksheet in the book. The free fillable versions on the website do the sums for you, and keep what you type on your own device.

Who did what

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01.html

Write down what actually happened this week, before anyone starts remembering it as a story. Write down only what you did or saw yourself; never fill in someone else's side for them.

Person A _____ Person B _____

Week beginning _____

Part A: Who did what, this week

One row for each task noticed or done, including the invisible ones: remembering, planning, booking, forms. Time spent only thinking, noticing or planning counts too: log it as "Thinking and planning".

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?

This week's totals

Person A: minutes (and %), of which noticed and handled without being asked _____

Person B: minutes (and %), of which noticed and handled without being asked _____

Workload balance score: 1 − (A% − B%, ignoring any minus sign) ÷ 100 = _____

Part B (optional), Kind ways to say no: say why the request is fair, say honestly what you have left, and offer something instead.

Describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it. How the score works: "How the numbers work", at the back.

How much are you carrying?

Fillable version: spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02.html

Fill this in on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it in for someone else.

Your name _____ Date _____

The checklist

Score each row based on how the last 24–48 hours have actually gone. Circle one: 0 = Not at all, 4 = Very true. Living with a long-term illness? Your physical row may always be high. That fills the tank; it isn't a mood.

	Not at all				Very true
Sleep debt (less rested than usual)	0	1	2	3	4
Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving)	0	1	2	3	4
Recent unresolved conflict (any source)	0	1	2	3	4
Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain)	0	1	2	3	4
Time pressure today specifically	0	1	2	3	4

How full is your stress tank?

Points (add the five circled numbers): _____ out of 20

Tank: points ÷ 20 = _____ out of 1.00

Higher means a fuller tank (and a lower battery). Under 0.30: light. 0.30 to 0.59: medium. 0.60 or more: high. Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour.

Optional

☐ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

Anything you want to name before talking

A high score is a way to press pause, not a way out. It means "let's come back to this tomorrow," not "this doesn't need to happen."

One owner per job

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03.html

Every regular job gets one owner: the person who does it and sees it through. If you like, add a helper or backup who pitches in, notices if it slips, or covers it on a bad week. List the invisible jobs too: forms, gifts, renewals, planning, appointments.

Date of this list

The split you agreed (optional)

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup (optional)	Size (optional)	Notes

How often: Daily, Weekly, Monthly, As needed, Ongoing. Size: Small, Medium, Big.

Does every job have an owner?

Jobs with an owner: _____ of _____ = _____ out of 1.00

Changes to the list (optional)

Date	What changed	Who

Where we've landed

Agreeing means everyone has read this version and knows who owns what. It doesn't mean every job feels perfectly fair, only that ownership is clear.

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

What keeps coming back?

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04.html

A monthly look-back, done together, across four weeks of Who did what and One owner per job. It looks for the tasks that keep slipping. The goal is to find where the setup needs a fix, not to tally what anyone owes.

Month

Part A: Gather the month's notes

List every task that was noticed but not done, or done only after being raised more than once. Mark an ✗ for each week it came up.

Task	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Times flagged

Part B: Sort each gap

Sort every task flagged twice or more. A **structural gap** has no clear owner (fix One owner per job now). A **capacity issue** has an owner who can't keep up (set a time for an honest conversation). A **one-off** has a temporary cause (note it and move on).

Task	Named owner on the job list? (Yes / No)	Classification	Action

Part C: Wrap up the audit

Structural gaps found

Capacity issues found

One-offs

Part D (optional): Thanked, or only noticed when it's missed?

Job	Gets thanked (Often / Sometimes / Rarely / Never)	Only noticed when missed? (Yes / No)	One way to notice it

Not a bill for the past, and not a performance review. A task with no owner is a gap in the setup, not a verdict on the person who kept covering it.

Say it so it lands

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09.html

A self-check each of you uses on your own side of a conversation. Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Your name _____ Date _____

Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

Raw reaction (optional, and just for you)

What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.) For example: "The bins went out late on Tuesday."

What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…) A feeling about you, not a verdict about them.

What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?) Something the other person can say yes to.

Before you react: four quick checks

Check	Circle one
Is this about a specific, nameable task or event?	Yes · No
Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot?	Yes · No · Not sure
Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said?	Yes · No
Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation?	Their words · A past pattern

A "No" or "Not sure" on the second check, a "Yes" on the third or "A past pattern" on the fourth are good reasons to pause first. A kind "not right now" and a time to come back keeps it honest.

The Calm-Down Kit

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11.html

A short plan, made ahead of time, for calming your body down enough to have the conversation, or to put it off honestly. Fill in Part A on an ordinary day, not a hard one. Your kit is yours; only the pause plan is made to share.

Whose kit is this? (your name) _____ Date _____

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first

Part A: My two defaults

Pick two calming steps now: asymmetric breathing (breathe in for 4, out for 6) · naming the room (5 things you see, 4 you hear, 3 you can touch) · weight and pressure (feet pressed flat into the floor, or something warm held in both hands) · gating (cutting noise and light: lower the lights, step out) · walking it out · a low, steady sound.

First default _____ Second, if the first isn't available _____

Part A: My pause line

Say how you are, how long you need, and when you'll be back: "I'm at capacity. I need ten minutes. I'll be back at quarter past."

_____

Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal _____ The shortest break we take _____

How we set the time to come back _____ The first sentence when we come back _____

Part B, in the moment: say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step.

Part C: Coming back

Still hot? Another round. Twice? Name a new time. Settled enough to listen? Go back at the time you named. (For number fans: your stress tank score, 0 to 1. Under 0.50 go back; 0.50 to 0.59 another round; 0.60 or above after two rounds, put it off.)

Time	What I did	How I feel now (Still hot / Settled enough)	Stress tank before (0–1)	Stress tank after (0–1)

Next small action _____ If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up _____

Where I've landed

☐ I'm going with this

Look at this again on (optional) _____

Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

The 90-second daily check-in

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13.html

Each person answers each prompt in one sentence, about their own day, and fills in only their own rows. No debating, no solving, no arguing back. Anything that needs a real discussion waits for the weekly catch-up.

Week beginning

Each day

Day	Person	Stress tank (Light / Medium / High)	One thing I appreciated today	One small thing that didn't feel great	One thing that would help tomorrow
Mon					
Mon					
Tue					
Tue					
Wed					
Wed					
Thu					
Thu					
Fri					
Fri					
Sat					
Sat					
Sun					
Sun					

The weekly catch-up (optional)

Skim the week for anything that came up more than twice, and move it to the right worksheet.

Sore spot that keeps coming up	Times this week	Move to (One owner per job / Say it so it lands / Keep watching)

Where we've landed

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

Same moment, different speeds

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-12.html

For a few moments that come round often, each person marks how fast they want to move, how much they want to talk, and how urgent it feels. Each person fills in only their own rows, ideally before looking at the other's. There are no right answers.

Date

Part A: Each person's speed

Speed: right away · within the hour · later the same day · after a night's sleep. Talk: quiet time first · a few words, then act · talk it all through. Urgency: low · medium · high.

Moment	Person	Speed	Talk	Urgency	What helps me (optional)
A plan changes at the last minute					
A bill, letter or form needs dealing with					
Something breaks or goes wrong at home					
One of us is upset about something					
Deciding what to do with free time					

Part B: Where your speeds differ

For each moment, count how many steps apart your answers are on each list. Start with the biggest gap: a difference in pace, not in how much anyone cares.

Part C: One small agreement

Moment	What we'll try	Try it until

Where we've landed

Agreeing means you have both seen the gaps and will try the agreement. It doesn't mean either of you has to change speed for good.

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

Not a compatibility test and not a diagnosis. Run it again every few months, or after a big change.

Is it us, or is it everything else?

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-14.html

A one-week log that keeps two things apart: pressure from outside (money, work, health, sleep, family) and friction that really starts between you. A line or two each evening, each person about their own day. Write what happened, not who was wrong.

Week beginning

Part A: Each evening

Day	Person	Outside pressure today (None / A little / A lot)	Where it came from	A tense moment between us (if any)	Looking back, it was mostly (Outside pressure / Between us / Some of both / Not sure yet)
Mon					
Mon					
Tue					
Tue					
Wed					
Wed					
Thu					
Thu					
Fri					
Fri					
Sat					
Sat					
Sun					
Sun					

Part B: The week at a glance

Tense moments on heavy days: _____ of _____

Part C: What got blamed on the wrong thing?

The moment	What it seemed to be about	What was really going on	What would help next time

Part D: One plan for the pressure

The pressure we're facing right now

How we'll flag a heavy day

What we'll go easy on until it passes

One bit of outside help we could ask for (optional)

Outside pressure explains a hard day. It doesn't excuse unkindness, and it doesn't make what anyone felt less real.

Keep your little rituals alive

Fillable version:
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15.html

Every three months or so, a short look at the small shared habits that keep you close: the morning coffee, the Sunday walk, the birthday breakfast. Nobody is to blame for one that lapsed.

Date

Part A: Our rituals, big and small

How it's doing: Alive (still happening, still means something) · Fading (on autopilot or less often) · Stopped · New idea. How often: Daily, Weekly, Monthly, Yearly, Now and then.

Ritual or habit	How often	How it's doing	What it gives us, or what got in the way

Part C: One to restart, or start

The ritual

The smallest version that still counts

The first time: when, and who will suggest it

What would make it easy to skip, and how we'll protect it (optional)

Part D (optional): One to let go, with thanks

The ritual

What it gave us

Where we've landed

☐ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)

Look at this again on (optional)

A ritual is something you would both miss, not a test of love. Look at this sheet again in about three months.

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. More at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Backstop

The second name on a job: someone who notices if it slipped and checks in kindly. Not a supervisor. A job counts as owned once it has an owner; the backstop is a good habit on top.

Battery

Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, how full your stress tank is: a fuller tank means a lower battery.

For example: After a poor night and a long workday, your stress tank is nearly full and your battery is low, so a small request feels big.

Calm-down plan

Your calm-down plan (once called the Calm-Down Kit) is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

For example: A glass of cold water, a walk to the corner, and three long breaths out.

Carrier wave

The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

For example: "Fine." can carry calm, hurt or tiredness. The carrier wave tells you which.

Check-in

A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

For example: "Load today: heavy. Thank you for the dishes. One small thing: the car. My ask: could you fill it up?"

Complacency

Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

For example: "How was your day?" "Fine." Months go by and nobody has asked a real question.

Drift

Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

For example: Three busy weeks, no real talk, and small things start to feel big.

Flooded

Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

For example: "I need twenty minutes. Can we talk again at eight?"

Frequency

Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

For example: One person answers a text in a minute; the other answers at the end of the day. Neither is wrong.

Gatekeeping

Holding on to how a home or child-care job must be done, so the other person steps back. Researchers first described it in mothers ("maternal gatekeeping"), but anyone can do it.

Kinship care

When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder

Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

Ledger

A notebook where you write down what happened, so you can look at it calmly later. The book works the same way: see what is really going on, without blame, then change one small thing.

The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

For example: Buying the gift is one job. Remembering the birthday, picking the gift and wrapping it are three more.

Mental load

The noticing, planning and remembering behind running a shared life: knowing the shoes are too small, booking the appointment, keeping the list. It is real work, even though nobody sees it.

My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

For example: Short night, busy day: the forecast says to keep big talks for tomorrow.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

For example: Sam owns the recycling: noticing it's full, taking it out and buying the bags.

Parallel parenting

Co-parenting with as little direct contact as possible: each home runs its own way, and messages stay short, polite and about the children.

Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

For example: A pressure of 40 leaves room in the day; 75 means go gently and leave big things for later.

Retune

To retune is to notice you've fallen out of step with someone and adjust together: slower, softer, or at a better time.

For example: "Can we start that again? I came in too fast."

Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

For example: You ask "When will you do it?" calmly. They hear pressure. Nobody meant harm, but it crackles.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 to 0.59 medium, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Unbilled debt

Unbilled debt is the work of a shared life that got done but was never noticed or thanked.

For example: You remembered the dentist appointment, and nobody knew there was anything to remember.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

For example: Some people need a plan in writing. Others think best out loud.

Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website.

For example: "Who did what" is a week's log of who did what.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

For example: "Rest is earned" can feel like plain fact, until you notice it was your family's rule.

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Research notes

The 83 studies and books the chapters mention, chapter by chapter, each with what it found in plain words and where to read it. Each entry was looked up and checked: most against the paper itself or its abstract, some (mostly older books) against a publisher's or library's record. Unchecked works are left out. The full list, with notes on how strong each finding is, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Reading research: a few words in plain English

The chapters often say how sure the research is: "a small study", "linked with", "didn't replicate". Here is what those words mean, so every note in the book is something you can weigh for yourself.

Correlational ("linked with")
Two things tend to go together: people who sleep less tend to argue more. It doesn't show which causes which, or whether a third thing, like a new baby, causes both.

Experiment
Researchers change one thing on purpose, ideally deciding by chance who gets it, and compare. Better at showing cause, though often in a lab, for a short time, with a small group.

Meta-analysis
A study of studies: it pools many studies of the same question. Usually more trustworthy than any one study, but only as good as the studies in it.

Replication
Doing a study again to see if the result holds. When a large team re-ran 100 published psychology studies in 2015, only about a third gave a clear result again, and the effects were on average about half as big. So one study is a start, not the end.

Effect size
How big a difference is, not just whether there is one. A result can be real ("significant") and still tiny. The book says "small" or "modest" when that is the case.

Who was studied
Much of psychology studies students in Western, educated, well-off countries. A finding may not fit every age, culture or kind of family, and many studies of couples looked only at a mother and a father.

Self-report
People answered questions about themselves. That is often the only way to ask about feelings, but memory and wanting to look good both creep in.

How the book labels things: a *Research note* describes published findings in plain words and says where the evidence is thin. *This site's idea* marks the book's own ways of putting things into practice, such as the worksheets and the setup score, which have not been tested in studies. The full list at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research also says how strong each finding is: strong, moderate or early.

PREFACE TO PART TWO

The work nobody sees

Allen, S. M., & Hawkins, A. J. (1999). *Maternal gatekeeping: Mothers' beliefs and behaviors that inhibit greater father involvement in family work.* Journal of Marriage and the Family, 61(1), 199–212. Defined maternal gatekeeping along three dimensions and, in 622 dual-earner mothers, classified about one in five as gatekeepers; they did more family work each week and had less equal divisions of labour.
doi.org/10.2307/353894

Clark, M. S., & Mills, J. (1979). *Interpersonal attraction in exchange and communal relationships.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 37(1), 12–24. Distinguished communal relationships (benefits given in response to needs) from exchange relationships (benefits given in return for benefits). When people wanted a communal relationship, being repaid in kind reduced attraction.
clarkrelationshiplab.yale.edu

Cowan, C. P., & Cowan, P. A. (1992). *When Partners Become Parents: The Big Life Change for Couples.* BasicBooks (New York); reissued 1999 (Erlbaum) and 2011. Based on the Becoming a Family Project, a long-term study of expectant couples, describes how strain and conflict between partners commonly rise across the transition to parenthood, and tests couples groups as prevention.
openlibrary.org/works/OL92708W

Daminger, A. (2019). *The cognitive dimension of household labor.* American Sociological Review, 84(4), 609–633. Interviews with 35 couples (70 interviews) identified four parts of household "cognitive labour": anticipating needs, identifying options, deciding, and monitoring. Women did more of it overall, especially anticipating and monitoring; deciding was shared more equally. The work was often unseen by both partners.
doi.org/10.1177/0003122419859007

Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968). *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

di Leonardo, M. (1987). *The female world of cards and holidays: Women, families, and the work of kinship.* Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society, 12(3), 440–453. Named "kin work": the cards, calls, visits, gifts and gatherings that keep extended families connected. In the families she studied, it was done mostly by women and often treated as effortless.
doi.org/10.1086/494338

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doi.org/10.1037/a0013969

Gordon, A. M., Impett, E. A., Kogan, A., Oveis, C., & Keltner, D. (2012). *To have and to hold: Gratitude promotes relationship maintenance in intimate bonds.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 103(2), 257–274. People who felt more appreciated by their romantic partners were more appreciative of their partners in return, and appreciation was linked with relationship maintenance and commitment.
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search.worldcat.org/title/9280843

Hochschild, A. R., with Machung, A. (1989). *The Second Shift: Working Parents and the Revolution at Home.* Viking Penguin (updated edition 2012, Penguin Books). Interviews and home observations of dual-earner couples with young children found that working mothers did much more of the housework and childcare, adding up to a large extra load over a year; many couples told themselves stories that the split was fair.
penguinrandomhouse.com

Kurdek, L. A. (2007). *The allocation of household labor by partners in gay and lesbian couples.* Journal of Family Issues, 28(1), 132–148. Among 43 gay and 36 lesbian couples where both partners worked full-time, household tasks were divided more evenly than is typical in heterosexual couples, often by negotiation and specialisation rather than gender.
doi.org/10.1177/0192513X06292019

Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996). *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* In E. S. Reed, E. Turiel, & T. Brown (Eds.), Values and Knowledge (pp. 103–135). Lawrence Erlbaum / Psychology Press. Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

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doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.3.322

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doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.3.389

Yavorsky, J. E., Kamp Dush, C. M., & Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J. (2015). *The production of inequality: The gender division of labor across the transition to parenthood.* Journal of Marriage and Family, 77(3), 662–679. Time-diary data from dual-earner couples showed a gender gap in total work opening up after a first baby: mothers took on most of the added childcare without cutting their paid hours; survey reports overstated how equal things were.
doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12189

Why we get out of tune

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doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3737.2001.00614.x

Carrère, S., & Gottman, J. M. (1999). *Predicting divorce among newlyweds from the first three minutes of a marital conflict discussion.* Family Process, 38(3), 293–301. In 124 newlywed couples, how the first three minutes of a conflict discussion went (more negative and less positive emotion) predicted which couples divorced over the next six years.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.1999.00293.x

Gilovich, T., Savitsky, K., & Medvec, V. H. (1998). *The illusion of transparency: Biased assessments of others' ability to read one's emotional states.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 75(2), 332–346. In several sets of studies, people overestimated how well others could read their internal states (for example, liars overestimated how detectable their lies were, and people thought their disgust showed more than it did).
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.75.2.332

Gordon, T. (1970). *P.E.T.: Parent Effectiveness Training.* New York: P. H. Wyden (book; revised 2000). A parenting book and course that popularised "I-messages": describing your own feelings and the effect of a behaviour rather than blaming the other person.
search.worldcat.org/title/670595

Gottman, J. M. (1994). *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

Kruger, J., Epley, N., Parker, J., & Ng, Z.-W. (2005). *Egocentrism over e-mail: Can we communicate as well as we think?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 89(6), 925–936. Across five experiments, people overestimated how well email recipients would detect their tone (such as sarcasm or seriousness), partly because they found it hard to step outside their own perspective.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.89.6.925

Lally, P., van Jaarsveld, C. H. M., Potts, H. W. W., & Wardle, J. (2010). *How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world.* European Journal of Social Psychology, 40(6), 998–1009. Following 96 volunteers who repeated a daily behaviour in the same context for 12 weeks, automaticity rose along a curve that levelled off; reaching 95% of each person's plateau took between 18 and 254 days, and missing a single day did not meaningfully set progress back.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.674

Lambert, N. M., Fincham, F. D., Stillman, T. F., Graham, S. M., & Beach, S. R. H. (2010). *Motivating change in relationships: Can prayer increase forgiveness?* Psychological Science, 21(1), 126–132. In two small experiments with students, people asked to pray for a romantic partner (study 1) or for a friend daily for four weeks (study 2) reported more willingness to forgive that person than people in comparison conditions; in study 2 this went with a rise in selfless concern.
doi.org/10.1177/0956797609355634

Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007). *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli.* Psychological Science, 18(5), 421–428. In a brain-imaging study, labelling the emotion in a picture reduced amygdala and other limbic responses compared with other ways of processing the image.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01916.x

Mahoney, A. (2010). *Religion in families, 1999–2009: A relational spirituality framework.* Journal of Marriage and Family, 72(4), 805–827. Reviewed a decade of peer-reviewed studies on religion in marriage and parent–child relationships, "for better and worse", organising them by how faith may help form, maintain and change family relationships; faith can strengthen family life and can also be a source of strain.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3737.2010.00732.x

Milton, D. E. M. (2012). *On the ontological status of autism: The "double empathy problem".* Disability & Society, 27(6), 883–887. A short conceptual paper arguing that misunderstanding between autistic and non-autistic people runs both ways: each side finds the other hard to read, so the problem lies between them, not only in the autistic person.
autism.org.uk/advice-and-guidance/professional-practice/double-empathy

Rosenberg, M. B. (1999). *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* PuddleDancer Press (Encinitas, CA); 2nd ed. 2003, 3rd ed. 2015. Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

Ross, L. (1977). *The intuitive psychologist and his shortcomings: Distortions in the attribution process.* Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, 10, 173–220. Reviewed the biases of the lay 'intuitive psychologist' and named the fundamental attribution error: underestimating situational causes and overestimating personal dispositions when explaining others' behaviour.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60357-3

Savitsky, K., Keysar, B., Epley, N., Carter, T., & Swanson, A. (2011). *The closeness-communication bias: Increased egocentrism among friends versus strangers.* Journal of Experimental Social Psychology, 47(1), 269–273. In three experiments, people overestimated how well they communicated with friends and spouses, more than with strangers, and made more egocentric errors following a friend's directions; closeness seemed to relax the checking people do with strangers.
sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0022103110002118

Yoo, S.-S., Gujar, N., Hu, P., Jolesz, F. A., & Walker, M. P. (2007). *The human emotional brain without sleep—a prefrontal amygdala disconnect.* Current Biology, 17(20), R877–R878. After a night without sleep, the amygdala reacted more strongly to negative pictures and was less connected to the prefrontal cortex.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2007.08.007

PART TWO · CHAPTER II

Is the split working?

Cohen, S., Kamarck, T., & Mermelstein, R. (1983). *A global measure of perceived stress.* Journal of Health and Social Behavior, 24(4), 385–396. Introduced the Perceived Stress Scale, a short questionnaire about how unpredictable, uncontrollable and overloaded your life has felt lately; scores went with symptoms of depression and illness.
doi.org/10.2307/2136404

Cowan, C. P., & Cowan, P. A. (1992). *When Partners Become Parents: The Big Life Change for Couples.* BasicBooks (New York); reissued 1999 (Erlbaum) and 2011. Based on the Becoming a Family Project, a long-term study of expectant couples, describes how strain and conflict between partners commonly rise across the transition to parenthood, and tests couples groups as prevention.
openlibrary.org/works/OL92708W

Daminger, A. (2019). *The cognitive dimension of household labor.* American Sociological Review, 84(4), 609–633. Interviews with 35 couples (70 interviews) identified four parts of household "cognitive labour": anticipating needs, identifying options, deciding, and monitoring. Women did more of it overall, especially anticipating and monitoring; deciding was shared more equally. The work was often unseen by both partners.
doi.org/10.1177/0003122419859007

Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968). *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

di Leonardo, M. (1987). *The female world of cards and holidays: Women, families, and the work of kinship.* Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society, 12(3), 440–453. Named "kin work": the cards, calls, visits, gifts and gatherings that keep extended families connected. In the families she studied, it was done mostly by women and often treated as effortless.
doi.org/10.1086/494338

Doss, B. D., Rhoades, G. K., Stanley, S. M., & Markman, H. J. (2009). *The effect of the transition to parenthood on relationship quality: An 8-year prospective study.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 96(3), 601–619. Following 218 couples over the first eight years of marriage, those who had a first child showed sudden declines in relationship quality after the birth, on average, compared with couples who did not.
doi.org/10.1037/a0013969

Feinberg, M. E., & Kan, M. L. (2008). *Establishing Family Foundations: Intervention effects on coparenting, parent/infant well-being, and parent-child relations.* Journal of Family Psychology, 22(2), 253–263. A randomised trial with 169 expectant first-time couples found that the Family Foundations classes, delivered before and after birth, improved coparenting and some aspects of parent and infant wellbeing at follow-up.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.2.253

Goodhart, C. A. E. (1975). *Problems of monetary management: The U.K. experience.* Paper presented at the Conference in Monetary Economics, Sydney, July 1975; published in Papers in Monetary Economics, Vol. I (Reserve Bank of Australia, 1976); reprinted in Goodhart, Monetary Theory and Practice (Macmillan, 1984). The original source of "Goodhart's law": a statistical regularity tends to break down once authorities put pressure on it for control purposes.
rba.gov.au/publications/rdp/1990/9013/conference-volumes.html

Hochschild, A. R., with Machung, A. (1989). *The Second Shift: Working Parents and the Revolution at Home.* Viking Penguin (updated edition 2012, Penguin Books). Interviews and home observations of dual-earner couples with young children found that working mothers did much more of the housework and childcare, adding up to a large extra load over a year; many couples told themselves stories that the split was fair.
penguinrandomhouse.com

Kurdek, L. A. (2007). *The allocation of household labor by partners in gay and lesbian couples.* Journal of Family Issues, 28(1), 132–148. Among 43 gay and 36 lesbian couples where both partners worked full-time, household tasks were divided more evenly than is typical in heterosexual couples, often by negotiation and specialisation rather than gender.
doi.org/10.1177/0192513X06292019

Ross, M., & Sicoly, F. (1979). *Egocentric biases in availability and attribution.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 37(3), 322–336. In five experiments (married couples, groups, basketball teams), people recalled more of their own contributions to joint work and took more responsibility than others gave them; spouses' estimates of their own shares typically summed to more than 100 percent.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.3.322

Strathern, M. (1997). *'Improving ratings': Audit in the British University system.* European Review, 5(3), 305–321. Anthropological commentary on the "audit explosion" in British universities; widely credited as the source of the popular phrasing of Goodhart's law (when a measure becomes a target, it stops being a good measure).
cambridge.org

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (annual, since 2003). *American Time Use Survey* (ATUS). Federal survey (conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau). The federal survey of how, where and with whom Americans spend their time, including unpaid housework and childcare; it has run every year since 2003.
bls.gov/tus

Yavorsky, J. E., Kamp Dush, C. M., & Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J. (2015). *The production of inequality: The gender division of labor across the transition to parenthood.* Journal of Marriage and Family, 77(3), 662–679. Time-diary data from dual-earner couples showed a gender gap in total work opening up after a first baby: mothers took on most of the added childcare without cutting their paid hours; survey reports overstated how equal things were.
doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12189

PART TWO · CHAPTER III

Full tanks and different angles

Amato, P. R. (2001). *Children of divorce in the 1990s: An update of the Amato and Keith (1991) meta-analysis.* Journal of Family Psychology, 15(3), 355–370. Updated a meta-analysis comparing children of divorced and continuously married parents; differences in wellbeing were small on average and persisted in studies from the 1990s.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.15.3.355

Cohen, S., Kamarck, T., & Mermelstein, R. (1983). *A global measure of perceived stress.* Journal of Health and Social Behavior, 24(4), 385–396. Introduced the Perceived Stress Scale, a short questionnaire about how unpredictable, uncontrollable and overloaded your life has felt lately; scores went with symptoms of depression and illness.
doi.org/10.2307/2136404

Emery, R. E. (1982). *Interparental conflict and the children of discord and divorce.* Psychological Bulletin, 92(2), 310–330. Reviewed evidence that conflict between parents, in married and divorced families, is linked to children's problems, and that the amount and type of conflict matter.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.92.2.310

Gottman, J. M. (1994). *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

Hetherington, E. M., & Kelly, J. (2002). *For Better or For Worse: Divorce Reconsidered.* W. W. Norton. Drawing on long-term studies of about 1,400 families, argues that most children of divorce and remarriage turn out reasonably well, with outcomes varying widely.
wwnorton.co.uk/books/9780393324136-for-better-or-for-worse

Jones, E. E., & Nisbett, R. E. (1971). *The actor and the observer: Divergent perceptions of the causes of behavior.* General Learning Press (short monograph). Proposed the actor-observer hypothesis: people tend to explain their own actions by the situation and others' actions by their dispositions.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/1098932900

Maccoby, E. E., & Mnookin, R. H. (1992). *Dividing the Child: Social and Legal Dilemmas of Custody.* Harvard University Press. Following more than a thousand separating families for three years, described three patterns of co-parenting among families where children spent time in both homes: cooperative, conflicted and disengaged; most parents avoided legal battles but many found it hard to cooperate.
hls.harvard.edu

Neff, K. D. (2003). *Self-compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself.* Self and Identity, 2(2), 85–101. Defined self-compassion as three parts: self-kindness instead of harsh judgement, common humanity instead of isolation, and mindfulness instead of over-identifying with painful feelings.
doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

Neff, L. A., & Karney, B. R. (2009). *Stress and reactivity to daily relationship experiences: How stress hinders adaptive processes in marriage.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 97(3), 435–450. Spouses under more stress outside the relationship reacted more strongly to everyday negative experiences within it.
doi.org/10.1037/a0015663

Papernow, P. L. (2013). *Surviving and Thriving in Stepfamily Relationships: What Works and What Doesn't.* Routledge. Describes "stepfamily architecture" and five common challenges it creates, drawing on research and clinical experience; closeness between stepfamily members typically builds slowly.
routledge.com

Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996). *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* In E. S. Reed, E. Turiel, & T. Brown (Eds.), Values and Knowledge (pp. 103–135). Lawrence Erlbaum / Psychology Press. Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

PART TWO · CHAPTER IV

Two kinds of fair

Adams, J. S. (1965). *Inequity in social exchange.* In L. Berkowitz (Ed.), Advances in Experimental Social Psychology, Vol. 2, pp. 267–299. Academic Press. Founding statement of equity theory: people compare the ratio of what they put in to what they get out with someone else's, and feel tension when the ratios differ.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60108-2

Allen, S. M., & Hawkins, A. J. (1999). *Maternal gatekeeping: Mothers' beliefs and behaviors that inhibit greater father involvement in family work.* Journal of Marriage and the Family, 61(1), 199–212. Defined maternal gatekeeping along three dimensions and, in 622 dual-earner mothers, classified about one in five as gatekeepers; they did more family work each week and had less equal divisions of labour.
doi.org/10.2307/353894

Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968). *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

Deming, W. E. (1986). *Out of the Crisis.* MIT Press (Center for Advanced Engineering Study), Cambridge, MA. Deming's case for quality management, arguing that most problems come from the system people work in rather than from individual workers.
eploes.lib2.uniwa.gr/Record/lib2_1%2F6426/Details?lng=el

Deutsch, M. (1975). *Equity, equality, and need: What determines which value will be used as the basis of distributive justice?* Journal of Social Issues, 31(3), 137–149. Argued that equity is only one of several justice principles, alongside equality and need, and proposed when groups favour each: equality in cooperative relationships, equity in economic ones, need in caring ones.
data.gesis.org/gesiskg/resource/zis-Deutsch1975Equity

Dew, J., Britt, S., & Huston, S. (2012). *Examining the relationship between financial issues and divorce.* Family Relations, 61(4), 615–628. In US national survey data on about 4,500 couples, financial disagreements were the strongest of the disagreement types in predicting later divorce, for both wives and husbands.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3729.2012.00715.x

Gottman, J. M. (1994). *What predicts divorce? The relationship between marital processes and marital outcomes.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ); reissued by Routledge. Gottman's report of his long-term studies of couples, including "flooding": feeling so physically overwhelmed in a conflict that listening and thinking become very hard.
routledge.com

Klontz, B., Britt, S. L., Mentzer, J., & Klontz, T. (2011). *Money beliefs and financial behaviors: Development of the Klontz Money Script Inventory.* Journal of Financial Therapy, 2(1), 1–22. In 422 respondents, beliefs about money clustered into four "money scripts" (money avoidance, money worship, money status and money vigilance), several of which were linked with income and net worth.
doi.org/10.4148/jft.v2i1.451

Kruger, J., Epley, N., Parker, J., & Ng, Z.-W. (2005). *Egocentrism over e-mail: Can we communicate as well as we think?* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 89(6), 925–936. Across five experiments, people overestimated how well email recipients would detect their tone (such as sarcasm or seriousness), partly because they found it hard to step outside their own perspective.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.89.6.925

Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007). *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli.* Psychological Science, 18(5), 421–428. In a brain-imaging study, labelling the emotion in a picture reduced amygdala and other limbic responses compared with other ways of processing the image.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01916.x

Papp, L. M., Cummings, E. M., & Goeke-Morey, M. C. (2009). *For richer, for poorer: Money as a topic of marital conflict in the home.* Family Relations, 58(1), 91–103. In home diary records of marital conflict, money was not the most frequent topic, but money conflicts were more pervasive, problematic and recurrent than other conflicts and more likely to stay unresolved.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3729.2008.00537.x

Rick, S. I., Small, D. A., & Finkel, E. J. (2011). *Fatal (fiscal) attraction: Spendthrifts and tightwads in marriage.* Journal of Marketing Research, 48(2), 228–237. Tightwads and spendthrifts tend to marry each other; the bigger the difference within a couple, the more conflict over money, which in turn predicts lower marital wellbeing.
doi.org/10.1509/jmkr.48.2.228

Ross, M., & Sicoly, F. (1979). *Egocentric biases in availability and attribution.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 37(3), 322–336. In five experiments (married couples, groups, basketball teams), people recalled more of their own contributions to joint work and took more responsibility than others gave them; spouses' estimates of their own shares typically summed to more than 100 percent.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.3.322

Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J., Brown, G. L., Cannon, E. A., Mangelsdorf, S. C., & Sokolowski, M. S. (2008). *Maternal gatekeeping, coparenting quality, and fathering behavior in families with infants.* Journal of Family Psychology, 22(3), 389–398. In 97 couples with infants, fathers were more involved in day-to-day care when mothers actively encouraged them (gate-opening); when mothers were highly critical (gate-closing), fathers' own beliefs about involvement mattered less.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.3.389

Stone, D., Patton, B., & Heen, S. (1999). *Difficult Conversations: How to Discuss What Matters Most.* Viking (New York); 10th-anniversary edition, Penguin 2010. A practitioner book from the Harvard Negotiation Project describing three conversations inside every hard conversation (what happened, feelings, identity) and the gap between intent and impact.
penguinrandomhouse.com

Taylor, M. J., McNicholas, C., Nicolay, C., Darzi, A., Bell, D., & Reed, J. E. (2014). *Systematic review of the application of the plan–do–study–act method to improve quality in healthcare.* BMJ Quality & Safety, 23(4), 290–298. Of 73 healthcare articles reporting the use of plan–do–study–act cycles, most did not report key features of the method, such as iterative cycles, small tests of change and real-time data.
doi.org/10.1136/bmjqs-2013-001862

Thibaut, J., & Walker, L. (1975). *Procedural Justice: A Psychological Analysis.* Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (Hillsdale, NJ). Founded procedural-justice research: people's judgments of whether a decision process is fair (especially having a voice) shape how satisfied they are with the outcome.
law.virginia.edu/node/127096

PART TWO · CHAPTER V

The monthly look-back

Boss, P. (1999). *Ambiguous loss: Learning to live with unresolved grief.* Harvard University Press. Named "ambiguous loss": losses without clear closure, such as someone physically absent but psychologically present, or present but psychologically changed (as in dementia), and suggested ways to cope.
bookshare.org/browse/book/2050897

Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968). *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 8(4), 377–383. Participants who believed others could also hear a person having a seizure were slower and less likely to help; the presence of others reduced each person's sense of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

Dekker, S. (2007). *Just Culture: Balancing Safety and Accountability.* Ashgate (2nd ed. 2012). Argues for a "just culture" that separates honest mistakes from reckless behaviour, and that who draws the line matters as much as where it is drawn.
relbib.de/Record/1613173431

Deming, W. E. (1986). *Out of the Crisis.* MIT Press (Center for Advanced Engineering Study), Cambridge, MA. Deming's case for quality management, arguing that most problems come from the system people work in rather than from individual workers.
eploes.lib2.uniwa.gr/Record/lib2_1%2F6426/Details?lng=el

Goodhart, C. A. E. (1975). *Problems of monetary management: The U.K. experience.* Paper presented at the Conference in Monetary Economics, Sydney, July 1975; published in Papers in Monetary Economics, Vol. I (Reserve Bank of Australia, 1976); reprinted in Goodhart, Monetary Theory and Practice (Macmillan, 1984). The original source of "Goodhart's law": a statistical regularity tends to break down once authorities put pressure on it for control purposes.
rba.gov.au/publications/rdp/1990/9013/conference-volumes.html

Hayslip, B., Jr., & Kaminski, P. L. (2005). *Grandparents raising their grandchildren: A review of the literature and suggestions for practice.* The Gerontologist, 45(2), 262–269. Reviewed research on custodial grandparents: the costs and benefits of raising a grandchild, how varied these families are, their need for social support, parenting, and help at several levels.
doi.org/10.1093/geront/45.2.262

Pillemer, K. (2020). *Fault Lines: Fractured Families and How to Mend Them.* Avery (Penguin Random House). Draws on the Cornell Reconciliation Project, including a national survey on estrangement and interviews, to show family estrangement is more common than people assume and that some people reconcile.
search.worldcat.org/oclc/1145305518

Reason, J. (1990). *Human Error.* Cambridge University Press. A theory of human error that sorts slips, lapses and mistakes, and introduced the layered-defences thinking behind the "Swiss cheese" model of accidents.
doi.org/10.1017/CBO9781139062367

Reason, J. (1997). *Managing the Risks of Organizational Accidents.* Ashgate (now Routledge). Describes how organisational accidents arise from latent conditions combining with front-line errors, and sets out ideas for a safety and "just" culture.
routledge.com

Strathern, M. (1997). *'Improving ratings': Audit in the British University system.* European Review, 5(3), 305–321. Anthropological commentary on the "audit explosion" in British universities; widely credited as the source of the popular phrasing of Goodhart's law (when a measure becomes a target, it stops being a good measure).
cambridge.org

Tversky, A., & Kahneman, D. (1973). *Availability: A heuristic for judging frequency and probability.* Cognitive Psychology, 5(2), 207–232. People judge how common something is by how easily examples come to mind. That usually works, but vivid or recent examples make some things seem more common than they are.
apps.dtic.mil/sti/pdfs/ADA045770.pdf

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